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Master plan notified; 40 lakh houses planned

Master Plan for Delhi-2047 will direct city's development in line with its future needs, says CM; will help address rising population in Capital, expected to reach 3.2 cr. in two decades: Manohar Lal; cap on height of buildings removed in most areas, clearing way for vertical expansion; FAR raised to 500

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

The Master Plan for Delhi-2047 was notified on Thursday, setting out a 20-year framework for housing, redevelopment, transport and urban expansion in the national capital.

The framework aims at nearly 43 lakh new houses, most of them aimed at meeting affordable housing needs, said Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal while unveiling the plan, along with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu.

Ms. Gupta called the document a “comprehensive road map” for the development of the national capital. “Keeping the Capital’s current challenges in mind, it will set the direction for development in line with its future needs. Better coordination between the Central and Delhi governments will give fresh momentum to the city’s development,” she said.

Mr. Lal said provisions in the MPD-2047 will help address the city’s growing population, which is expected to reach 3.2 crore within the next two decades, and housing demand despite limited land availability.

The plan was approved by the Delhi Development Authority on August 12.



L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu, Union Urban Development Minister Manohar Lal, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and other dignitaries at the unveiling of the MPD-2047 in New Delhi on Thursday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Of the proposed 40 lakh houses, the largest component will come from transit-oriented development (TOD), followed by land pooling, redevelopment of slum clusters and group housing societies, and high-density development corridors along Urban Extension Road-II, said DDA vice-chairperson N. Saravana Kumar.

High-density growth
The master plan introduces high-density development, transferable development rights and town planning schemes while simplifying several land-use and building regulations, added Mr. Kumar.

The maximum height restrictions for buildings of all kinds, including residential and commercial, have been removed across most of the national capital, except in areas includ-

ing the Lutyens’ Bungalow Zone, Civil Lines Bungalow Area, Connaught Place, the Yamuna floodplains, the Ridge, land pooling and low-density areas, and locations subject to restrictions imposed by the Archaeological Survey of India and the National Monuments Authority.

Under the revised TOD policy, development will be promoted within 500 metres on either side of metro corridors and around the Regional Rapid Transit System and railway stations. The minimum plot size for TOD has been reduced from 10,000 sq m to 2,000 sq m while the maximum floor area ratio – the ratio of a building’s total built-up area to the total area of the plot – has been increased from 300 to 500. Land pooling is expected to enable nearly 200 sq km of planned ur-

ban expansion and a road network of about 600 km.

The DDA will develop roads of 30 metres and above upfront in these areas to support planned growth, said the Union Minister.

The plan also seeks to make the redevelopment of existing areas easier. The minimum plot size for redevelopment of group housing projects has been reduced from 40,000 sq m to 3,000 sq m.

To promote ease of doing business, the number of land-use categories has been reduced from 133 to 45. The plan proposes single-window online approvals for TOD, change of land use and layout plans.

New economic activities such as data centres, integrated industrial parks, co-working spaces and start-up hubs have also been included in the MPD-2047.

Roads to be priority in new development zones, says DDA V-C

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) will prioritise the development of road networks in new areas identified for development, including land pooling zones, low-density areas and high-density corridors along the Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II), under the Master Plan for Delhi-2047, DDA vice-chairperson N. Saravana Kumar said on Thursday.

He said road network plans for areas marked under the land pooling policy and low-density areas are expected to be notified within the next three to four months. “The plan is to take arterial roads from the land-pooling areas and the low-density areas and connect them to the NCR roads,” Mr. Kumar said. These roads will have a right of way of 30 metres or more, in line with MPD-2047 provisions.

The DDA plans to develop key roads under the land pooling model upfront instead of waiting for landowners to deposit external development charges before infrastructure

work begins. “The development of roads will be a priority for us,” he said.

The urban body has around 15 projects ready for approval under the land pooling policy, with one already sanctioned. Mr. Kumar said land required for roads and infrastructure will be made available by participating landowners through the land pooling process.

Uniform framework

The road network will also guide development in the low-density areas, which covers nearly 150 sq km along Delhi’s peripheral villages and the 23 notified villages under the earlier Low Density Residential Area framework. The master plan envisages a uniform planning framework for these areas while retaining their low-intensity character and providing for residential, institutional, recreational and other permissible uses.

For high-density corridors, particularly those along UER-II, the DDA will prepare a separate plan in sync with the plans for adjoining land-pooling areas, said Mr. Kumar.

Conviction after 34 years: how Sajjan Kumar dodged law

Soibam Rocky Singh
Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Former Congress MP from Outer Delhi Sajjan Kumar faced trial in three cases linked to the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, which resulted in two convictions and an acquittal.

The first conviction came in December 2018, 34 years after the violence, when the Delhi High Court overturned his acquittal by a trial court and sentenced him to life imprisonment for the killing of five Sikhs and the burning of a gurdwara in Delhi Cantonment’s Raj Nagar area.

The High Court called out Delhi Police’s “abject failure” in investigating the anti-Sikh riots and described the Raj Nagar case as one in which there appeared “large-scale efforts to suppress” proceedings against Kumar. His involvement came under scrutiny well before the conviction, with committees formed to probe his role in the violence recommending action against him.

The Jain-Banerjee Committee recommended that a case be registered against him in 1987. The Potti-Rosha Committee made a similar recommendation in 1990, followed by the Jain-Aggarwal Committee in the same year. The Narula panel, which reviewed the earlier findings in 1993-94, also recommended an FIR

against Kumar. The Nanavati Commission, set up in 2000, recorded that witnesses alleged Kumar’s involvement and found “credible material” to conclude that he was “probably involved as alleged by the witnesses”. It recommended that cases in which he had been named but chargesheets had not been filed and closed as untraced be examined afresh. However, the recommendations did not result in prompt prosecution.

His second conviction came in February 2025, when a city court sentenced him to life imprisonment for the killings of Jaswant Singh and his son Tarandeep Singh in Saraswati Vihar on November 1, 1984. The court described the offences as “undoubtedly brutal and reprehensible”, but said his age and illnesses weighed in favour of life imprisonment instead of the death penalty.

Jail life until death
Kumar was initially lodged in Mandoli Jail before being transferred to Tihar Jail, where he remained until his death on Thursday. At Tihar, he was lodged in Ward No. 15 of Jail No. 4, in the geriatric care unit. Given his physical condition, Kumar was provided a wooden cot and mattress, said a prison official.

SEE ALSO
» PAGE 15

With key convict dead, survivors recall horror

Lavpreet Kaur
Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI



Victims of 1984 anti-Sikh riots staging a protest. FILE PHOTO

For Harpal Singh*, the news of former Congress MP Sajjan Kumar’s death on Thursday brought back traumatic memories from over four decades ago.

“He burnt people alive,” said Mr. Singh, a 60-year-old car driver, recalling the violence he witnessed Kumar inflict on the Sikh community. Mr. Singh had arrived in Delhi from Amritsar a month before the 1984 anti-Sikh riots. He was 15. Mr. Singh said he escaped the violence because he did not wear a turban and had no beard. But he watched other Sikh men being attacked.

“They put burning rubber tyres around the necks of Sikh men in front of my eyes. I saw people from my own community screaming, crying, and burning. That memory terrorises me even today,” he said.

Another eyewitness, Anand Banerjee*, recalled the violence beginning in Kidwai Nagar. “A Sikh

man’s store was brought down. The rioters then attacked the gurdwara and burnt it down,” he said.

“The violence did not stop there. Two buses parked outside the market were also set on fire, killing and injuring people. Many were burnt alive,” Mr. Banerjee recalled. He also remembers Sikh colleagues desperately seeking shelter with others as mobs moved through their neighbourhoods. “Many later returned to work without their turbans, with their hair cut, just to hide their identities,” he said.

For residents of areas such as Palam, Kalyanpuri, Hari Nagar, and Jhungpura, the memories of those

days remain deeply etched in their minds. Among them is Jagdish Kaur, whose testimony and appeal were central to the case in which the Delhi High Court convicted Kumar in 2018. “Justice has been evasive for the victims of the violence. Police, Army, all were party to the crime,” Ms. Kaur said.

Her husband, Kehar Singh, a gun-fitter in the Army, was beaten to death with rods inside their home by a mob. Her 18-year-old son, Gurpreet Singh, tried to flee but was caught by another mob and burnt alive. Ms. Kaur said that when she went to the police station to lodge a complaint, she heard Kumar trying to instigate a mob against Sikhs. “I could not expect the police to help me when the SHO himself was party to the mob,” she said. The FIR was registered on November 3. By then, the bodies of her husband and son had remained at her home for three days, she said.

(*Names changed on request)

HIMACHAL PRADESH PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT
No.: PW/EDP/CB/TA/NIT/2026-27/-3194-98
Dated: 19-08-2026

"E-Procurement Notice"
Invitation for Bids (IFB)

The Executive Engineer, Electrical Division, HPPWD Palampur, Distt. Kangra, HP on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh invites the percentage rate bids in Two Covers system in Electronic Tendering System from approved and eligible contractors/firms registered with HPPWD (E) fulfilling the qualifying criteria along with the documents for the works as detailed below in the table:

Sr. No	Name of Work	Estimated Cost	Earnest Money	Time Limit	Cost of bid document
1.	Providing and laying of SOP cable for new 3T MRI machine installed at old OPD 12 area of maternity block ground floor of 500 bedded hospital at Dr. RPGMC Kangra at Tanda.	15,03,079/-	30,100/-	Three months	350/-
2.	CONSTRUCTION OF ADARSH GRAM SUKH AASHRYA PARISAR VILLAGE LUTHAN, TEHSIL JWALAMUKHI, DISTT. KANGRA, H.P.(SH: Providing Campus Lighting therein, with 2 years on site AMC).	1,51,25,600/-	3,02,600/-	Along with civil work	5000/-
3.	Construction/Establishment of 50 Bedded Critical Care Block And DIPHL at Civil Hospital Dehra, Tehsil Dehra Distt. Kangra (H.P.)/Sh:Providing Medical Grade Breathing and Therapeutic system therein).	1,37,24,361/-	2,74,500/-	Along with civil work	5000/-
4.	Supplying and fitting of spares 1 (One) Numbers Six Passengers Machine Room Less "KONE" make Elevator installed in Circuit House at Dharamshala.	205000/-	4100/-	One Year	350/-
5.	Annual repair and comprehensive maintenance 01 no 15 passengers cum stretcher machine room less elevator "KONE" make installed in Anatomy block , lecture theatres and examination hall Dr. RPGMC Kangra at Tanda for three tears i.e 2026-2027 to 2028-29.	3,97,129/-	27,300/-	Three years	350/-

Key/ Critical Dates:	Publish Date/Time	27-08-2026	5.00 PM
2.	Document Download Start Date/Time	27-08-2026	5.00 PM
3.	Bid Submission Start Date/Time	27-08-2026	5.00 PM
4.	Bid Submission End Date/Time	03-09-2026	10.00 AM
5.	Bid Opening Date/Time	03-09-2026	11.30 AM

The bidders are advised to note other details and terms & conditions of tenders from the departmental website www.hptenders.gov.in.

Executive Engineer, Electrical Division, HPPWD Palampur - PIN-176061
e-mail: ee-elgchp@nic.in
HP / 2784/26-27 him suchana avam jan sampark On behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh

THE HINDU
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LEGAL NOTICE
IN THE HONOURABLE COURT OF PRINCIPAL CIVIL JUDGE (JUNIOR DIVISION) AT VISAKHAPATNAM
OS No-1229/2025 I.A. No-735/2026
Gorle Appa Rao Petitioner
Between
Defendant-1 Pemmaraju Venkata Satyanarayana Rao S/o. P. Sri Rama Chandra Murthy D.No: 369, Second Floor, Block-A M.G. Road, Sullampur, New Delhi-110030
Cell No: 7471182172, 8331829349, 9315168277
Defendant-2 Smt. Pemmaraju Savitri W/o. P. Satya Narayana Rao D.No: 369, A-Block, II nd Floor, M.G. Road, Sullampur, New Delhi, Pin-110030
Cell No: 9315168277, 7993139419
Aadhar No-935217797099
Defendant-3 Pemma Raju Sri Rama Chandra Murthy, S/o. Subbaiah (Late), APMG (Retd), D.No: 369, A-Block, II nd Floor, M.G. Road, Sullampur, New Delhi, Cell No: 7471182172, 8639150877, 9109303918
PUBLIC NOTICE
The hearing for the aforementioned O.S. No. 1229/2025, I.A.No. 735/2026 suit is scheduled for 28-09-2026. To date, neither you, your lawyer, nor your legal heirs have appeared in court. Therefore, you are hereby informed to appear on 28-09-2026; otherwise, the matter may be decided in your absence (ex parte). Pemmaraju Srirama Chandra Murthy S/o. Late Subbayya - Boundaries: A-Block, FFF, Manju Shankar Apartments, Prashanthi Nagar, Assessment No. 1171006303; B-Block, 26, Manju Shankar Apartments, Prashanthi Nagar, Secunderabad, Assessment No. 1171006303.
By Order
In the hon'ble court of principal civil judge (Junior Division at Visakhapatnam)
Date: 20-08-2026. Advocate for Petitioner **GORLE APPARAO** 37-7-54, MK Gardens, Visakhapatnam-7, Cell: 7399095586

PERSONAL
CHANGE OF NAME
I, SUBODH Kumar Gupta, s/o Sh. Rameshwar Dayal, r/o P-4, Flat No. 402, Putting Green, NRI City, Greater Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P. - 201310, declare that Subodh Kumar Gupta (Aadhar Card) and Subodh Kumar (Driving Licence) are one and the same person. Vide Affidavit dated 19-08-2026 and numbered IN-UP38124738112292Y at Greater Noida.
PUBLIC NOTICE
PUBLIC NOTICE
Public is hereby informed that VIJAY ACADEMY OF LEARNING SOCIETY is running school namely Vijay Public School @ Vijay College of Education Medical School has claimed to the owner of a Plot Bearing no-11, area measuring 252.91 sq. mtrs. Comprised in Kharsa no. 1988, situated at Mahindra Endive, Village Razapur, Pargana Daina, Tehsil & district Ghaziabad U.P. And Now VIJAY ACADEMY OF LEARNING SOCIETY has approached Avasan Financial Services Ltd. for loan against mortgage of above said property. If any person has any right, claim, title or interest in any manner over the said property or named of society then intimate within 7 days to Madhvi Saini Advocate office at 4th Floor, Office No. 468, Tower S-3, Cloud Vaishali, Ghaziabad U.P. (Mob: 8810513493) Thereafter any kind of claim will not be accepted.
MADHVI SAINI ADVOCATE
office at: 4th Floor, Office No. 468, Tower S-3, Cloud 9, Vaishali Ghaziabad U.P.

**OFFICE THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD (R&B) DIVISION NAGROTA**

SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDER
e-NIT No. 58 of 2026-2027 Dated 18-08-2026
Executive Engineer PW (R&B) Division Nagrota, Jammu on behalf of Lieutenant Governor of Union Territory of J&K, invite tenders by e-tendering on item rate basis mode from Approved and Eligible Registered Firm for the following work:-

S. No	Name of Work	Cost of the Project Excluding work Charge and Contingence (in Lacs)	Advt. Cost of consultancy charges including all taxes in Rs. In	Cost of Tender Doc.	Earnest Money in Shape of CDR/FDR /BG	Time Allowed for Completion	Time & Date of Opening of Tender (Technical Bid)
1	Engagement Of Consultant For Providing Consultancy Services Including Survey, Detailed Geotechnical Investigations, Hydrological Detailed Study, Structural Design, Estiamtaion, Preparation Of Boq & Getting It Vetted From Iit, Nit, Dicc, Goet Jammu Or Any Other Govt. Engineering College For Re-construction Of Unsafe Bridges Double Lane Through Type Plate Girder Bridge With Food Path 18.00 Mtr At Raipur Lower Doman, 20.00 Mtr At Gurah Brahmana Patoli Akhnoor And At 22.00 Mtr Span Double Lane At Lower Kote Khas (purkhoo) Over Ranbir Canal	488.50	6.10		Rs. 600/- Treasury Challan Under MH 0059-PW (Rev).	20 Days	25-08-2026 (1400hr)

Eligibility:-Architect should be registered with the Council of Architecture.
1. The Bidding documents consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website www.jktenders.gov.in as per below schedule:-as per below schedule:-

Date of Issue of Tender Notice	18-08-2026
Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 19/08/2026, 10:00 A.M to 24/08/2026, 6.00 P.M
Bid submission Start Date	19/08/2026 from 10:00 A.M
Bid Submission End Date	24/08/2026 from 6:00 P.M
Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	25/08/2026 from 2:00 P.M

No. EE/ND/5240-50 Dt:- 18-08-2026
DIP/J-8364/26 Aug 19 2026
Executive Engineer
PWD(R&B) Division Nagrota

**DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS KATHUA**
E-mail: sspkathua@jkpolice.gov.in Fax/Phone No.: 01922-234010

LOOK OUT NOTICE
On 14-08-2026, one person namely Maan Chand S/O Rama R/O Banjal Tehsil Bani District Kathua lodged a written report at P/S Banistaling therein that on 03-08-2026 his daughter-in-law namely Babli Devi, age 24 years went missing from home. The complainant made best efforts to search for his wife but all in vain. On this, missing report vide DD No. 08 dated 14-08-2026 has been entered at Police Station Bani.
During the course of investigation, best efforts were made to locate missing lady, whereas she is still untraced.
As such Description Roll/Photograph of said missing individual is being shared with the appeal that anybody having clue/information about her whereabouts may inform us accordingly. The informer will be rewarded suitably:-
PHOTOGRAPH

Description Roll:-	
• Name	Babli Devi
• Husband	Parshotam Kumar
• Permanent Address	Banjal
• Present Address	Bani
• Teshil	Bani
• Police Station	Bani
• Age	24 years
• Height	5 feet 03 inch
• Complexion	Fair
• Build	Normal
• Face	Oval
• Eyes	Black

Any information related to his identity may be communicated on following contacts:-
1. DPO Kathua- 01922-234010 (Phone/Fax)
2. dpokathua@jkpolice.gov.in (Mail ID)
3. PCR Kathua-01922-234311(Phone/Fax)
4. Police Station Bani 913007515
5. **SHO P/S Bani-9186316021**
DIP/J-8378/26, Aug 19 2026
Sr. Superintendent of Police, Kathua.

**GOVERNMENT OF TAMIL NADU**
REGISTRATION DEPARTMENT
No. 100, Santhome High Road, Foreshore Estate, Chennai – 600 028

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Tender Reference No.: TNREGN/2/2026-27, dated 21.08.2026
Online tenders are invited from eligible bidders for the Selection of a Service Provider for Scanning, Digitisation and Meta-tagging of Records and Indexing of Encumbrance Certificates for the Registration Department, Government of Tamil Nadu. The details of the tender are as follows:

	Additional Inspector General of Registration (S & R), O/o, Inspector General of Registration, No.100, Santhome High Road, Foreshore Estate, Chennai-600 028.
1 Tender Inviting Authority	
2 Name of the Work	Selection of Service Provider for Scanning, Digitisation & Meta Tagging of Records and Indexing of Encumbrance Certificates.
3 Downloading of Tender Document	The tender document may be downloaded, free of cost, from the website https://tntenders.gov.in from 21.08.2026 to 23.09.2026 (up to 5.00 PM).
4 Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)	Rs.1,00,00,000/- (Rupees one crore only) , to be remitted through online mode.
5 Pre-Bid Meeting	28.08.2026 at 4.00 PM , at the address mentioned in Sl. No.1 above.
6 Due Date, Time & Place of submission of the tender	On or before 23.09.2026 up to 5.00 PM , through e-submission at https://tntenders.gov.in .
7 Date, Time and Place of opening of the tender	The Technical Bid will be opened on 24.09.2026 at 3.00 PM . The date of opening of the Price Bid will be intimated to the technically qualified bidders only.

The tender document, complete terms and conditions, detailed scope of work and eligibility criteria are available at <https://tntenders.gov.in>.
Note: Neither the Registration Department nor its representatives shall be obliged to intimate the bidders who are not qualified at any stage of the bid process management.
DIP/R/ 2632 /Tender/2026
Additional Inspector General of Registration (S & R)

Skipped CWC
meet with
permission to
appear for
exam: Channi



Mr. Venugopal, who arrived in Chennai after attending the Congress Working Committee meeting in New Delhi, said the meeting had discussed several issues concerning students, including exam irregularities, paper leaks, and their uncertain future. He said Mr. Gandhi had taken up the concerns of students, and had cautioned the Prime Minister nearly a year ago that their grievances were not being heard. Despite this, the BJP had mocked Mr. Gandhi when he questioned the

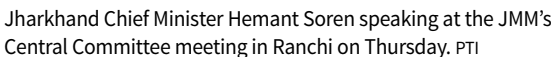
decision to conduct exams across such a large country through a single agency, he said. Mr. Venugopal, who attended a meeting of the Tamil Nadu Congress Committee's general body at Kamarajar Arangam, described the present moment as "a new era for Tamil Nadu – a Kamarajar era for Tamil Nadu". TNCC president Nanickam Tagore spoke about strengthening the party at the grassroots level.

Former Punjab Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi on Thursday said party high command allowed him to skip the Congress Working Committee (CWC) meeting as he was to appear in an examination at Panjab University here. The CWC meeting was held in Delhi on Wednesday.

Besides party president Mallikarjun Kharge, senior leaders Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and several top leaders and special invitees besides all four Chief Ministers of Congress-ruled States attended the marathon meeting held in the aftermath of the students' agitation on paper leaks and the Ram Temple donations row.

Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren on Thursday said his government would oppose the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, (MMDR Bill) on every democratic, constitutional and legal front, alleging that the Centre passed it without taking States into confidence.

“The Centre has made changes to the existing MMDR Act that are highly adverse and truly unfortunate. These will seriously impact every tribal, Dalit, poor person, farmer and labourer in the State,” Mr. Soren said addressing reporters here.



The Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) president chaired the party's extended central committee meeting here, where various issues, including the MMDR Bill, were discussed.

Mr. Soren questioned the Centre's decision to pass the legislation without consulting the State governments and asked who would compensate the

States for the losses expected to arise from the changes. "It appears the Central government will not even compensate for past losses," he said.

He added that Jharkhand had already submitted a claim to the Centre for outstanding dues of ₹1.36 lakh crore from coal companies.

Parliament passed the Bill on August 13. The legis-

lation seeks to restrict the States' powers to levy taxes on mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands.

"We strongly oppose it, and we will also fight battles against it at the democratic, constitutional, and legal levels," Mr. Soren said.

He alleged that the Central government appears far more sensitive towards developed States and feels a greater sense of accountability towards them. "There is absolutely no sign of empathy for adivasis, Dalits, or the backward classes," he said.

Terming it a matter of serious concern for Jharkhand's future, the Chief Minister said they will continue to discuss the matter and determine future

strategy.

Left to stage stir

Meanwhile, Left parties announced to launch a week-long agitation across the State from August 25 to protest against the Bill. The announcement was made during a joint press conference by the members of Left parties, including CPI, CPI(M), CPI(ML) Liberation, SUCI and Forward Bloc, here. "We will burn copies of the Bill in every village, block and district of the State from August 25 to 31," CPI State secretary Mahendra Pathak said.

However, All Jharkhand Students Union (AJSU) Party chief Sudesh Mahto hit out at the ruling JMM terming its opposition to the Bill a "political stunt".

DELHI

The Bombay High Court on Thursday halted the Mumbai civic body's plan to convert Neville D'Souza Football Ground at Bandra Reclamation into an exhibition or convention centre. A Bench of Acting Chief Justice Ravindra V. Ghuge and Justice Gautam A. Ankhad directed the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) to refrain from taking any steps until the next hearing on September 18.

The court asked the civic body where people would play football if its plan went ahead. It took cognisance of an oral assurance the BMC had made to the court earlier, stating that the assurance by the BMC's lawyer was not communicated to BMC Commissioner Ashwini Bhide.

The Bench observed that some space must remain open, otherwise the next generation would forget outdoor sports and grounds. It noted that the majesty of law was at stake if elected authorities acted

against court orders. The court indicated it would take *suo motu* action unless the BMC reversed its position.

The development came a day after the Mumbai Football Association flagged a BMC move to clear a proposal to convert the ground, despite earlier assurances to the contrary. Defending its move, the BMC told the court that its general body had taken the decision only to publish a notice inviting suggestions and objections from stakeholders.

Delhi Weather	max	min
Delhi City	36	25
Safdarjang	36	25
Palam	34	23

Delhi Palam Today
34°C The weather will be warm and uneasy. Night will be comfortable. Spell of light rain and thundershower with gusty winds to occur.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
35°C The weather will be warm. Spell of light to moderate rain and thunder-shower to occur. Night will be comfortable.

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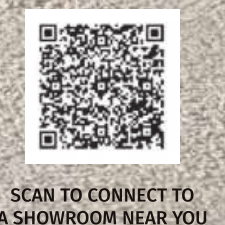
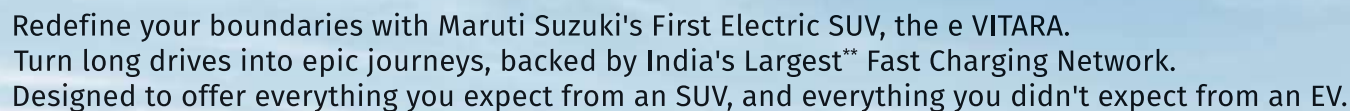
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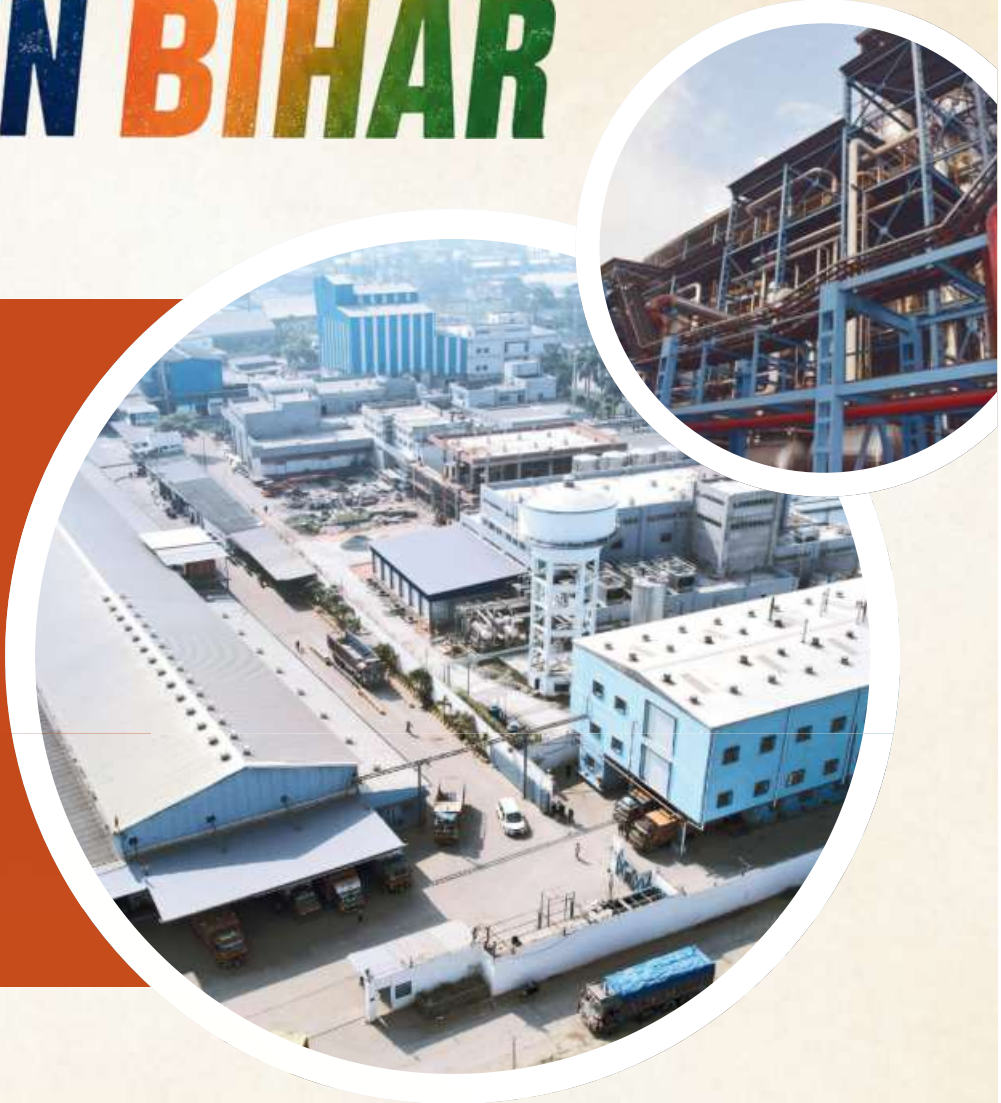


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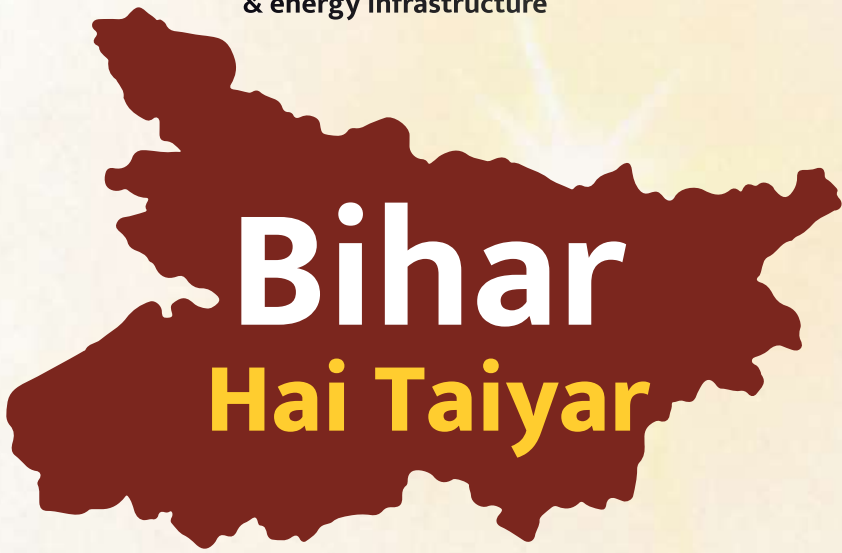
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10-member team leaves for Delhi over demand for Manipur NRC

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

A 10-member team comprising leaders of different communities and organisations in Manipur left for New Delhi on Thursday amid the unrest in Imphal Valley to press for an updated National Register of Citizens (NRC) before the Census exercise is conducted in the State.

The departure of the team, representing members from the Meitei, Pangal (Manipuri Muslims), Naga, and other indigenous communities, coincided with the boycott of Central and State government offices in Manipur on the day.

The Campaign for Just and Free Delimitation, a civil society and student-led movement at the forefront of the pro-NRC movement, announced an indefinite boycott across five districts in Imphal Valley. The boycott started after a 48-hour general shutdown ended on Wednesday.

“We will take the people’s demand for an Assam-like exercise to update the NRC in Manipur before Census and delimitation to Union Ministers, Bharatiya Janata Party leaders, and Intelligence Bureau officials,” a team leader said before leaving for Delhi.

Day after violence, Assam, Meghalaya CMs call for peace

Sarma and Sangma underscore need to explore ways to restore peace, trust, and normalcy; drivers’ body blocks Shillong vehicles along border

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Chief Ministers of Assam and Meghalaya on Thursday sought restraint from the people of both States to recover from the impact of violence during a protest rally in Shillong on Wednesday.

Thirty-one vehicles, mostly Assam-registered, were damaged, at least a dozen people were assaulted, and some vehicles were torched during the bike rally organised by the Khasi Students’ Union (KSU). The bikers wore black masks and covered the registration plates of their two-wheelers.

Meghalaya Chief Minister Conrad K. Sangma said he spoke to his Assam counterpart Himanta Biswa Sarma regarding the violence and the reactions that followed, which affected common people and commuters in both States.

“We have agreed to work together, as always, to normalise the situation. Designated Cabinet Ministers from both States will meet to take the discussions forward and explore



Conrad K. Sangma



Himanta Biswa Sarma

ways to restore peace, trust, and normalcy,” Mr. Sangma said, appealing to the people of both States to maintain peace, harmony, and restraint.

“Meghalaya and Assam share deep bonds, and we must work together to protect them,” he said.

Mr. Sarma said he conveyed Assam’s concern over the recent incidents in Shillong to his Meghalaya counterpart. Insisting that deep historical, cultural, and people-to-people ties bind the two States, he said, “Mutual respect, restraint, and sensitivity must guide us at all times.”

Meanwhile, vehicular movement between Guwahati and Shillong was dis-

rupted on Thursday as Assam-based transporters responded peacefully to the violent students’ rally.

Members of the Assam State Drivers’ Association prevented the entry and exit of Meghalaya-registered vehicles, barring ambulances, along the arterial Guwahati-Shillong road at Jorabat on the border between the two States. Meghalaya police vehicles had to turn back too. The blockade followed the arrest of three leaders of the KSU in connection with the violence. “We raided the KSU office and arrested three leaders of the group,” Vivek Syiem, the East Khasi Hills Superintendent of Police, said.

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Notice inviting information's from reputed Security Printing Organization for confidential Printing. Details of information to be sent by organizations may be seen on website of the Board <https://rajeduboard.rajasthan.gov.in>

Secretary

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY E-Auction Notice

No. C/54/ Khanpan /TSV/e-Auction Date: 19.08.2026

The bids are invited from registered entities on IREPS by Sr. DCM/IZN (ACO) through e-Auction for the Train Side Vending service contracts. The Catalogue has already been published on IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in. The detail of upcoming e-Auctions of Izzatnagar division is as under:

Category	Catalogue no.	Auction Start	Auction End		
TSV	IZN-MMS-MobGen	28-08-26/12:00:00	28-08-26/12:40:00		
Sr.No	Train No.	Type	From	To	Frequency
1	15056-55	Exp.	RMR	AF	Tri-Weekly
2	15020-19	Exp.	TPU	DDN	Tri-Weekly

1. Bidders are advised to visit website www.ireps.gov.in for more information related to e-Auction. 2. The bids have been invited through e-Auction Leasing module of IREPS website. 3. All the e-Auction related information as eligibility, scope of work, contract period terms & conditions of contract etc. are available on IREPS. 4. Bidders can participate in e-Auction only as per the date & timing as indicated above. 5. All the prospective bidders are requested to visit website www.ireps.gov.in regularly for any corrigendum related to above e-Auctions.

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(Government of Himachal Pradesh)

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The Department of Treasuries Accounts & Lotteries invites the online tenders for appointment of Sole Selling Agent for Sale of paper / online Lotteries of the Government of Himachal Pradesh in the State of HP.

Last date and time for online bid submission ("Bid Due Date"):-14/09/2026 , 4:00 PM

The Bid document is available on <https://hptenders.gov.in/nicgep/app>. The bidders are advised to note details from the above mentioned website. Any corrigendum/addendum to the tender documents shall be published on above website.

(Director)
Directorate Treasuries Accounts & Lotteries
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CMC/BY/26-27/RB/ SkS/APT/26 [RFx no: 2200000240]	Rate contract for supply of polycarbonate security meter seals (Orange & Blue colour) in BYPL	1.00 Crore	2.00 Lakh	15:00 Hrs 11.09.2026	11:30 Hrs 11.09.2026
CMC/BY/26-27/RB/ SkS/APT/27 [RFx No. 2200000241]	Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning (SITC) for Precision Air-conditioning (PAC) System of data centre in BYPL	1.00 Crore	2.00 Lakh	15:00 hrs 31.08.2026	15:30 hrs 31.08.2026
CMC/BY/26-27/RB/ SkS/APT/28 [RFx No. 2200000242]	Supply of Laptops with MS-office LTSC Standard perpetual license for windows OS in BYPL	3.72 Crore	7.44 Lakh	15:00 hrs 31.08.2026	15:30 hrs 31.08.2026

Cost of Tender Document: ₹1,180/- each

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फॉर्म-6

नए मतदाता के लिए

यदि आप 18 वर्ष की आयु पूर्ण कर चुके हैं और आपका नाम मतदाता सूची में नहीं है, तो फॉर्म-6 भरें।

नया नाम जोड़ने हेतु

फॉर्म-7

नाम हटाने के लिए

यदि किसी का नाम स्थानांतरित हो गया है, मृत्यु हो गई है या दोहराव है, तो फॉर्म-7 भरें।

नाम हटाने हेतु

फॉर्म-8

विवरण सुधारने के लिए

यदि आपके नाम, आयु, पता, फोटो या अन्य विवरण में कोई गलती है, तो फॉर्म-8 भरें।

विवरण सुधारने हेतु

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INBRIEF



Former CM of Mizoram gets BA certificate after 60 years

Former Mizoram Chief Minister and Mizo National Front (MNF) president Zoramthanga on Thursday received his Bachelor of Arts (BA) degree certificate from Gauhati University, nearly six decades after completing his graduation. Mr. Zoramthanga, who graduated in 1966 from Dhanamanjuri (DM) College in Imphal, then affiliated to Gauhati University, was presented with the certificate at a special lecture-cum-interactive programme organised in his honour at the Phanidhar Dutta Seminar Hall of the university, according to a statement released by the MNF. PTI

Shah to visit Bengal to attend meetings on border security

Union Home Minister Amit Shah will arrive in West Bengal's Siliguri on Thursday evening for a three-day visit to the State, during which he will attend programmes and chair review meetings related to border security and interact with Sashastra Seema Bal personnel, officials said. Mr. Shah will arrive at Bagdogra airport from Tamil Nadu at around 8 p.m. and proceed to Sukna, where he will stay overnight, they said. The Home Minister's visit assumes significance as the Siliguri corridor is a strategically important stretch connecting the northeastern States with the rest of the country. PTI

T.N. CM seeks fair, equitable treatment of southern States

At Southern Zonal Council meet, Vijay says southern States are among principal drivers of the nation's economic growth; DMK criticises CM's comments on delimitation, accuses him of 'U-turn'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Southern States do not seek preferential treatment, but fair and equitable treatment that respects fiscal autonomy, rewards performance alongside equity, and enables well-performing States to continue investing in the infrastructure, innovation, and human capital that drive India's growth, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay said on Thursday.

At the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council held at Mamallapuram, which was presided over by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Mr. Vijay said the southern States contribute over 30% of India's Gross Domestic Product (GDP), and have consistently been among the principal drivers of the nation's economic growth.

"As India prepares for the next Finance Commission, the fiscal devolution framework must recognise both need and performance. States that have invested in development, fiscal discipline, and demographic transition



Warm welcome: Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay greeting Union Home Minister Amit Shah at the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council in Mamallapuram on Thursday.

should not be placed at a disadvantage," Mr. Vijay said.

Stating that no agenda for southern cooperation was complete without addressing shared rivers, he said, "Two principles must guide us. First, the legitimate rights of lower riparian States and the livelihoods that depend on assured river flows must be fully protected. Second, the Supreme Court judgments, the awards of the tribunals, and the statutory mechanism for river management must be implemented in letter and spirit."

On the Cauvery, he said the timely implementation

of the Supreme Court's judgment and the decisions of the Cauvery Water Management Authority remained essential. On Mullaperiyar, he said the dam's safety must continue to be guided by judicial decisions for increasing the water level to 152 feet.

Delimitation row

The Chief Minister's take on delimitation at the meeting triggered a row on Thursday. Mr. Vijay, in his address, urged the Union government to provide a clear legislative assurance that "no State would suffer a reduction in its percentage of representation in Parliament" on account of

its success in population stabilisation. He said such an approach would uphold the principles of equity, preserve the federal balance envisioned by the Constitution, and reinforce the confidence of all States in democratic institutions.

However, some of the Opposition parties were quick to point out that the address was at variance with the resolution adopted by the Tamil Nadu Assembly on August 12, which had called for a "freeze" on the number of Lok Sabha seats at 543.

The DMK, the main Opposition party, urged Mr. Vijay to explain why he had taken a "U-turn" on delimitation after adopting a resolution in the Assembly. DMK MP Dayanidhi Maran wondered whether the Chief Minister had switched over to the BJP alliance, or had developed cold feet after seeing the Union Home Minister.

Tamil Nadu Law Minister C.T.R. Nirmalkumar later clarified that there was no change in the Tamil Nadu government's stand on delimitation. "Freeze 543 & 39 for TN," he said in a post on X.

No motive behind circular to principals on student protests

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Higher Education Minister P. Viswanathan on Thursday told the Assembly that the State government did not have any ulterior motive in sending a circular to college principals in connection with student protests.

He was referring to a recent directive issued by the Higher Education Department, citing Chief Secretary M. Sai Kumar's diktat, which had sought coordinated action to prevent students from participating in protests organised by the Left parties and the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP). The order was withdrawn following outrage.

Replying to CPI members T. Ramachandran and Marimuthu in the Assembly, Mr. Viswanathan said the objective of the circular was to "ensure discipline and peace" on college campuses.

"The government has no plans to control the rights of students and the youth. This government respects the genuine rights of students," he said.

The Minister said the Higher Education Department had sent the circular to the Commissioner of



Tamil Nadu Higher Education Minister P. Viswanathan

Collegiate Education on August 17 to stress the need to maintain discipline and peace in colleges during State-wide protests.

Subsequently, the Directorate sent a circular to all college principals asking them to submit a report by Thursday.

Errors in circular

"When it was noticed that some words referring to certain political parties and organisations had been wrongly included in the circular, it was immediately withdrawn," Mr. Viswanathan said.

Earlier, Revenue Minister K.A. Sengottaiyan said action was being initiated against the tehsildar in Dindigul district who had directed revenue officials to collect details of members of the CPI and the CPI(M).

Rajasthan Cong. MLAs boycott first day of Monsoon Session over entry curbs in govt. schools

Mohammed Iqbal
JAIPUR

The Opposition Congress boycotted proceedings on the first day of the Monsoon Session of the Rajasthan Assembly on Thursday in protest against the State government's recent decision to restrict the entry of outsiders in government schools. The Congress MLAs staged a dharna outside the Assembly and demanded Education Minister Madan Dilawar's resignation.

Inside the House, Speaker Vasudev Devnani expressed disappointment over the absence of Opposition members, while the ruling party's chief whip and two Ministers said the Congress MLAs had remained absent to avoid participating in the full rendition of national song *Vande Mataram*.



Cong. MLAs staging a protest outside Rajasthan Assembly on the first day of Monsoon Session on Thursday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The Assembly proceedings were adjourned till Friday after obituary references.

Protesters stopped

The Congress legislators, led by Leader of Opposition Tika Ram Jolly, marched from the Government Seth Anandilal Podar School for the Deaf and Mute towards the Assembly after being denied entry

into the school. When the police stopped them with barricades, there was a brief scuffle between the protesters and police personnel.

The Congress MLAs sat on dharna outside the Assembly and raised slogans, alleging that thousands of schools in the State had dilapidated buildings, shortage of teachers and lack of basic facilities.

Former extremists meet Tripura Governor, seek rehabilitation package

Syed Sajjad Ali
AGARTALA

Representatives of two forums of surrendered extremists met Tripura Governor Indrasena Reddy Nallu to press for their demands on Thursday, a day after they withdrew their call for a State-wide agitation following appeals from the State government.

The Joint Action Rehabilitation Committee (JARC) and the Joint Action Committee (JAC) had planned to block roads and railway tracks on Wednesday morning to highlight their demands. Both groups represent former extremists who surrendered to authorities over the past 30 years. They hail from at least five outlawed organisations that once waged an insurgency for a separate tribal homeland.

According to officials, these former extremists were not among groups

that surrendered as part of peace agreements with the State government at the initiative of the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA). The members of the JARC and the JAC laid down arms without preconditions and, as a result, could not be accommodated in the MHA's rehabilitation package, the officials said.

The representatives said they had earlier met both the Governor and the Chief Minister to discuss their demands. They claimed that the government had given them assurances of support, but nothing materialised on the ground.

Facing hardships

The representatives said several former extremists are ageing and that their families are facing hardships in the absence of a rehabilitation package. They also threatened to launch an indefinite stir if their demands are not fulfilled.

Calls grow for BCI chairperson's ouster as 200 advocates protest outside Mishra's office in Delhi

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

Calls for the ouster of Manan Kumar Mishra as the chairperson of the Bar Council of India (BCI) grew louder on Thursday, with over 200 lawyers in Delhi staging a protest outside his office over several issues, including pending BCI reforms and the NALSAR episode.

The controversy around the NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad, stems from a BCI circular issued on August 13 directing State Bar Councils not to enrol graduates from the university after students opposed the participation of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant at their convocation. The circular was withdrawn hours later following an outcry. Two days later, Mr. Mishra, a senior advocate and BJP MP,



Advocates protesting against BCI chairperson Manan Kumar Mishra in Delhi on Thursday. ANI

apologised to law students.

However, the August 13 circular has continued to draw condemnation from senior advocates and other bar members, including NALSAR's alumni, many of whom have asked the BCI chairperson to step down.

Flak from Mumbai

On August 18, the Bombay Bar Association issued a statement criticising Mr. Mishra's handling of the NALSAR episode and de-

scribed his apology as "belated". It added that he "ought to have already resigned" from the post.

During Thursday's protest in Delhi, protesters under the banner of the All India Young Advocates Association questioned Mr. Mishra's 14-year stint as the BCI chairperson.

"He has been the chairperson for the last 14 years. He has been winning the election only because of the indirect election system. We want reform in the BCI election mechanism. We want direct election for the chairperson's post," advocate Umesh Kumar told *The Hindu*.

Another protester, advocate Satvik Sharma, said, "The legal system is deteriorating day by day. The chairperson himself has said 30-40% of advocates are fake. So what are they doing about it?"

Odisha forms panel to examine relocation of villages from Satkosia Tiger Reserve

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

The Odisha government has constituted a high-level inquiry committee to examine the relocation of villages from the Satkosia Tiger Reserve (STR) following allegations by residents that they were forcibly evicted from their ancestral villages despite having coexisted harmoniously with wildlife for decades.

The committee headed by the Revenue and Disaster Management Secretary would examine the entire village-wise relocation process relating to the STR, except Raiguda, which was the first village to be relocated after following the proper procedures.

The notification regarding the formation of the



Villagers had alleged that they were forcibly evicted. FILE PHOTO

committee was issued on August 17.

The panel has been mandated to examine and verify compliance with applicable statutory provisions, including the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972, the Forest Rights Act, 2006, and guidelines of the National Tiger Conservation Authority.

Beneficiary identification would also be scrutinised to find out if villagers were wrongfully excluded or included in the relocation process. Assessment of compensation and rehabilitation provided to the affected families will also be examined.

The committee has been directed to recom-

mend appropriate corrective measures, including payment of differential compensation, restoration of rights, and livelihood support.

The State government has particularly asked the committee to identify the officers responsible for any procedural irregularities or violations and recommend appropriate departmental and criminal action against them.

Zero tiger population

The STR has a troubled history of tiger conservation. The State's 2007 census recorded 12 tigers but by 2018-19, just one remained.

The 2022 tiger census recorded none, leaving the reasons behind the population's disappearance unresolved.

Mining project: HC asks petitioner to move tiger conservation body

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

The Bombay High Court's Nagpur Bench has directed a petitioner to approach the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA), observing that the authority is best placed to determine whether the area for a mining project in Gadchiroli is connected to the Tadoba-Indravati tiger corridor and therefore requires wildlife clearance.

The court was hearing the matter related to the 937-hectare mining project in Maharashtra's Gadchiroli district and its potential impact on tiger movement corridors and wildlife habitat. According to the court order published on Wednesday, the petitioner had not made any prior representation to the authorities

The HC was hearing a matter related to a mining project in Maharashtra and its potential impact on tiger movement

before filing the plea and it should therefore be filed through the NTCA, given the organisation's specialised statutory role.

The court has granted permission for withdrawal of the plea and approaching the NTCA directly with a representation raising the same grievances.

The petition was filed last month by Mumbai based-lawyer and social activist Sagar Kantilal Devre in Mulund (East), Mumbai, with the NTCA, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, the

State of Maharashtra, and others as respondents.

The plea challenges three regulatory approvals comprising environmental clearance, Stage-II forest clearance, and wildlife clearance exemption granted for diversion of 937.077 hectares of forest land at villages in Gadchiroli in favour of Lloyds Metals and Energy Ltd. for an iron ore mining project.

According to the petitioner, the region falls under the Tadoba-Indravati tiger corridor and the project was exempted from wildlife clearance without considering the statutory Tiger Conservation Plan and NTCA guidelines.

The government cleared the project proposal on May 13, triggering a backlash from environmentalists and social activists.

Preacher sentenced to death in POCSO case

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUNELVELI

The Special Court for cases registered under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act in the district has awarded four death sentences to a preacher who sexually assaulted four minor girls in 2022.

According to the prosecution, S. Abraham, 50, a preacher who ran a prayer hall at Mela Ilanthaikulam near Thevarkulam, sexually assaulted four minor girls under the pretext of taking moral classes during vacation. The girls narrated their ordeal to their parents, who filed complaints with the Tirunelveli Rural All Women Police.

CM
YK



Students thanking the Madhya Pradesh government after Ujjain MP Anil Firojiya assured them that their school would not be shifted away. A.M. FARUQUI

Gen Alpha rises, one school at a time

India's government schools have faced criticism over broken infrastructure, poor learning outcomes, and unsafe food. Now, students, inspired by the Gen Z protests, have begun to question those in charge of their education. **Mehul Malpani** captures the protest from Ujjain, where 300 girls brought the administration to their school, forcing them to change the merger of their school with one many kilometres away

As the bell that signalled the end of the school day rang at 2.30 p.m. on August 18, scores of girls rushed out of Ujjain's Maharani Lakshmbai Government Girls Senior Secondary School, Sarafa, with cheers and chants of victory. They were celebrating an assurance from the Madhya Pradesh government that their school would not be shut and merged with a school in Daudkhedi village, 6 km away. Many had tears in their eyes – they would be able to continue their studies.

Located opposite the famous Mahakaleshwar Jyotirlinga Temple in Ujjain, the government girls' school was founded in 1959. Most students here come from the rural pockets around. The celebrations, teachers say, are a result of the girls' struggle and courage that they showed as they raised their voices before government authorities.

On August 13, local newspapers had reported the merger of various schools. Under the Madhya Pradesh government's ongoing merger exercise, 10 more schools, five each from Ujjain city and nearby villages, are being shifted to Daudkhedi, impacting 2,978 students, as per a March 30 order from the Department of Education. Sarafa was to be the 11th.

On August 14, a day before India's 80th Independence Day, more than 300 girls of the school, most between Classes 9 and 12, gathered at the campus. Instead of going to their classrooms, they headed to the Ujjain Collector's office and staged a protest against the government's plans to shift their school.

The demonstration, videos of which went viral in no time, saw the girls, many with their parents, raising slogans against the move, even as some of them broke down. Two girls fainted. Finally, the administration assured them that their voices would be heard.

As per the government's Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) 2023-24 data released by the Ministry of Statistics, India's female literacy rate stands at 74.9% for those aged 7 and above.

Over the past month, school children in various parts of the country, mostly in India's northern States ruled by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), like Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, and Rajasthan, have risen up to question those in power. Protests are around the education system and its access: broken roads leading to schools, teacher shortages, crumbling classrooms and toilets.

Gen Alpha rising

Most students were inspired by the Gen Z protests over question paper leaks and other irregularities in the competitive examination system. The protests had begun in New Delhi and then spread across the country, leading to the resignation of then Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, a move considered unprecedented for Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Central government in its 12 years of rule.

The police brutality on students during their July 20 Sansad Chalo march to Parliament further angered a large section of the nation's youth and their parents, a trusted voter base for the ruling BJP.

While the Gen Z protests largely involved college-going urban youth, the Gen Alpha uprising is seeing school students in small towns and rural regions questioning those responsible for their

My children leave at 7 in the morning by bus and return only by 7 in the evening. How will such small children study after a 12-hour day

A father

education. There is now a growing push for accountability and transparency.

On July 13, students of Eklavya Model Residential School (EMRS) in Chhindwara district's forested Tamia tehsil raised angry slogans on the school campus alleging poor meal quality in hostels, saying there were worms in their food. Angry students, who gathered outside the school campus in the rain, demanded that the District Collector come and hear their woes. The school administration had not acted on their complaints, they said. The EMRS are Union government-run institutions for students from tribal communities.

On August 15, a group of primary and middle school students from Chandla area in Madhya Pradesh's Chhatarpur district stopped the convoy of State Cabinet Minister and local MLA Dilip Ahirwar. They were angry about a broken road to their school, the absence of a boundary wall, and no electricity.

The same day, scores of schoolchildren, accompanied by some adults, from Chhatarpur's Maharajpur tehsil set out on a 40-km march to the district headquarters over infrastructural woes, including a drain that swells in the rains, which the students have to cross to reach their school. Even though the march was stopped, as senior district officials went to meet the protesters, the protest went on for 18 hours and only ended after Maharajpur BJP MLA Kamakhya Pratap Singh met them after midnight.

On August 19, several children of a government primary school and their parents from Damoh district's Arth Kheda village staged a demonstration at the Collector's office over their school building. They said it was dilapidated and its roof could cave in with the rains. They raised slogans like, "Hum apna bhavishya maangte; hum apna school maangte (We demand our future; we demand our school)." They alleged that repair work in January did nothing for the building, and they were tired of administrative assurances. The school is currently being conducted at a temporary location in the village, a protestor said.

Uttar Pradesh, India's most populous State with over 200 million people, has so far witnessed four such demonstrations by Gen Alpha students in the last month, in Hamirpur, Azam-



Sandipani Government Senior Secondary School in Daudkhedi village of Ujjain, in which 10 schools from the city and nearby villages are being merged. A.M. FARUQUI

garh, and Fatehpur, besides Lucknow, all over the lack of the basics.

On August 17 in Uttar Pradesh's capital Lucknow, over 200 students from Jai Prakash Narayan Sarvodaya Vidyalaya for Girls, marched roughly 3 kilometres to the Dubagga-Kanpur bypass to protest against the shortage of teachers and inadequate basic amenities in their school. There have been similar protests in Rajasthan's Alwar and Barmer districts, and Bihar's Gaya.

Governments feel the pressure

The August 14 protests by the girls in Ujjain prompted top BJP leaders and local officials to visit the school and hold discussions with the students on August 18, the next working day at the school, after the Independence Day-Nag Panchami weekend.

The protest held significance as Ujjain is the hometown of Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav and a long-standing stronghold of the party that rules the State and is at the Centre. His sister, along with BJP MP from Ujjain Anil Firojiya and Ujjain North MLA Anil Jain Kaluheda showed up at the school with several other administrative staff, including the District Collector.

"Chief Minister Mohan Yadav was informed about the proposal to relocate the Sarafa school to Daudkhedi. Keeping the convenience of the female students in mind, the Chief Minister immediately directed that their classes continue at the existing Sarafa school until alternative arrangements are made," Firojiya said. He added that work would also be undertaken to construct a better school building after identifying a suitable site in the vicinity.

The quick outreach for the girls also holds significance as women are considered a trusted voter base of the ruling BJP, and were credited as an important factor in the party's landslide victory in the 2023 Assembly elections despite anti-incumbency. After the meeting, a group of girls broke down while thanking the leaders.

Monika Sisodia, a Class 12 (commerce) student and one of the girls who led the protests, says, "While we were very disturbed when we found out that our school would be shifted, the August 13 news triggered us. We did not discuss our plans to protest with the teachers, but we decided to fight for our education." Monika says that the girls had read about the Gen Z protests and were inspired by them.

"We have won the fight now, but we were ready to even go on a hunger strike to save our school. Had this not happened, many girls would have had to quit their studies," says Monika, who dreams of becoming a police officer.

When asked if they feared online abuse, threats and trolling that many of the Gen Z protesters have had to face in the aftermath of their agitation, Monika and her peers said they are not active on social media.

A teacher, standing nearby, said, "Some of us teachers and parents were concerned about the possible consequences. So, we spoke to the students and advised them not to engage in any political slandering or language that may be problematic." This came in the wake of criticism from a section, on the Gen Z protests, around abusive language.

Future and studies at risk

While the Sarafa school has got a lease of life, the 10 other schools to be merged with Daudkhedi are seeing dropouts. Prem Singh Parihar, who was the principal of Mahakal Maidan middle school, which has been merged, says that 117 students have taken their transfer certificates (TC) since April, bringing the school's strength down from 282 to 165.

"Most parents who came to get the TCs had the same concern. They did not want to send their children so far. While some have borne the extra financial burden of sending their children to private schools nearby, there are a few who cannot afford it," he says. More than 75 girls left the Sarafa school after their Class 10 results, with the news that their school would be merged, teachers at the school say. The overall strength of the school came down from 580 to 415 for the academic 2026-27.

Nutan Middle School, Jaisinghpura, which has also been shifted to Daudkhedi, has seen 90 of its

300 students taking their TCs, as per data shared by the school. Ujjain Collector Singh, however, denies the dropout claims and says that some teachers who do not want to travel far to work are "making false claims" to prevent shifting.

The school in Daudkhedi has a modern building with 90 classrooms, facilities, and a large campus. The school is surrounded by fields and an open drain runs through its campus making it unsafe.

Even though the government is currently running school buses for travel, students and parents have raised concerns for the children's safety and the extra time spent commuting. For many students who travel from nearby villages, the distance to Daudkhedi goes up 15-20 kilometres.

Most of the students' parents work as daily-wage labourers, while some drive autorickshaws, or sell food and flowers in the temple town. They say that dropping and picking up their children from Daudkhedi will mean a loss of their daily earnings.

"My children leave at 7 in the morning by bus and return only by 7 in the evening. How will they study after a 12-hour day," says the father of two primary school students, who now go to Daudkhedi. He works as a driver for a local BJP leader and does not wish to be named.

Many children also work after school to help their families financially and fear that extra travel time would hamper their work and studies alike.

Roshni Prajapati, a Class 11 (Arts) student at the Sarafa school, said, "My father drives an autorickshaw, so I make cotton lamp wicks after school and earn about ₹50 every day to help my family. There are many girls who sew or apply mehendi for some extra earnings. My parents, and many others, had told us that we may have to quit studies if our school was shifted."

Several teachers and parents oppose school mergers, but would rather not go public, fearing backlash from local BJP leaders and the administration in future. "Officials have already asked school administrations to find out if the teachers had motivated the students to protest. Some of our names have already reached the authorities," a senior teacher from a school says, requesting anonymity.

Burdened teachers and rising vacancies

On August 17, Vidhi Singh, 15, the daughter of a farm labourer and a student of Lucknow's Sarvodaya Vidyalaya, walked over 2 kilometres in the rain. Her four companions suggested they take shelter until the rain slowed. She was resolute: "Let's reach the bypass. Our march is more important." Vidhi wanted to reach the spot where hundreds of others were protesting. "It may help to address the shortage of teachers," she says. "Very few classes were being held due to the teacher shortage. This is impacting our studies in core subjects. We need qualified teachers immediately," Vidhi adds. This year, she and her companions will take the Class 10 board exam.

In the heavy rainfall, the girls formed a human chain and sat down on the Dubagga-Kanpur bypass, demanding the Lucknow District Magistrate come to the site to address their concerns. They voiced their worries about the poor quality of food, the lack of medical services, power cuts, and high-handed staff. The demonstration followed an earlier demonstration on August 14, where over 100 students from the boys' campus of the same institution, managed by the Social Welfare Department, blocked a road to voice similar concerns. Finally, senior officials from the Social Welfare Department and district administration engaged with the students, listened to their concerns, and escorted them back to the school. "We were promised that all our grievances would be solved within a week," adds Vidhi.

Sadanand Mishra, a retired Government Primary School teacher in Lucknow calls the protests the tip of the iceberg. He claims the crisis is much deeper and structural. "Most of the teachers' working hours are spent on non-teaching duties like midday meal distribution, data collection, election duties, HR processes like transfers and leave applications," says Mishra, who is a member of the Uttar Pradesh Prathamik Shikshak Sangh, a teachers union.

A 2020 report by the National Institute of Educational Planning and Administration pointed out that only 19% of a teacher's annual school-working hours were spent on teaching activities.

Mishra adds, "It's been over five years with no job vacancy for primary teachers advertised in Uttar Pradesh. Numerous young people completing teacher-training degrees are waiting for job opportunities despite lakhs of posts vacant."

A report published by NITI Aayog in November 2023 stated that there were 2.1 lakh vacant teaching positions across government schools in U.P.

On August 15, the Cockroach Janta Party, which was one of the entities that led the Gen Z protests, began its 'School theek karo (fix the school)' campaign. Its founder Abhijeet Dipke is visiting schools across the country and documenting the gaping holes in governance.

Days after the announcement and in the wake of Gen Alpha protests in some districts, the Rajasthan government imposed a restriction on outsiders entering government schools and barred photography and videography without written approval, while citing the "safety and privacy" of students. In an X post, Dipke asked, "All those working in the education department, including Ministers, officials, principals and teachers, should enrol their own children in govt schools. Then watch how quickly our govt schools magically improve. Why do all of them enrol their kids in private schools? Do they not trust their own work?"

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With inputs from Mayank Kumar in Uttar Pradesh



Dhruv Kapoor

In early October 2025, Michelin awarded Keys to 2,457 hotels worldwide. In India, 36 received recognition. Hotels aspire to many benchmarks over their lifetime. Broadly, these fall into two categories. The first is self-determined: Once a threshold of polish and luxury is met, a hotel is classified as a three, four or five-star property. This hierarchy, while demanding, is largely within the hotel's control.

The second category is far more elusive – where certain accolades distinguish the best among the best. At the very top of this sits the Michelin Guide. Known globally for its restaurant stars, Michelin has recommended hotels since the early 1900s. In 2024, it formalised this with the introduction of Michelin Keys – a three-tier recognition for hotels delivering experiences beyond the ordinary. Inspectors assess properties across five criteria: architecture and interior design; quality and consistency of service; overall personality and character; value for price; and meaningful contribution to their setting.

In India, there are 14 one-Key, 20 two-Key, and two three-Key properties. To understand what truly separates these tiers, I tried some inspector-style role-play:

Keys to the city

From one Key to three: a first-hand look at how Michelin Key hotels differ in design, service and guest experience

experiencing services from one hotel in each category – a destination retreat, a metropolitan legacy hotel, and a palace hotel – mapping each experience against Michelin's five criteria.

One Michelin Key: Six Senses Vana, Dehradun
Approaching Vana, nothing prepares you for what lies within. Barely minutes from urban chaos, the property reveals itself as a sealed oasis. Phones are restricted, photography and outside food are prohibited. Guests or *vanavasis* are asked to wear identical white kurta pyjamas, subtly reinforcing equality while eliminating decision fatigue. The experience begins with a wellness assessment, leading to a personalised daily programme

spanning Ayurvedic, Tibetan, and natural healing therapies. Initially apprehensive, I found that surrender was encouraged, essential, and deeply rewarding. Architecturally, Vana is modern and restrained. It is a contrast to the ancient Indian philosophies practised within. This dissonance may not work for everyone, but it feels intentional. Where Vana truly distinguishes itself is its food. Contrary to expectation, meals are indulgent and rooted in Ayurvedic principles and seasonal, local sourcing. Wellness here is holistic: physical therapies, digital detox, craft practices, meditation spaces, with a deep spiritual undercurrent. The retreat operates with quiet precision through exceptional service. At roughly \$1,000 or around ₹95,000 a night,

The royal treatment (Clockwise from left) The Imperial in Delhi; Taj Lake Palace, Udaipur; Six Senses Vana, Dehradun. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



inclusive of meals and treatments, I arrived expecting a luxury resort. I left having experienced something transformative.

Two Michelin Keys: The Imperial, New Delhi
Hidden beside Connaught Place, The Imperial is discreet yet impossible to miss. Walking in feels like stepping through decades at once. Chandeliers glow, uniforms recall old cinema, and time seems to slow. "Welcome to the Grand Dame," someone says. And it lands. Not because of age alone, but because of authority. This is a hotel that shaped the idea of luxury in India rather than chased it. The Imperial blends Victorian, Art Deco, and colonial styles with confidence. Its most extraordinary asset lies beyond architecture: an art collection of over 5,500 works displayed across corridors and floors, curated by theme and geography. The hotel has borne silent witness to history, hosting political

conversations that shaped modern India. Table No. 14 at the 1911 restaurant, Mahatma Gandhi's preferred table, remains preserved as "The Gandhi Table". Antiques abound – silver cutlery, century-old furniture, heritage doors – yet nothing feels untouchable. The spa, restaurants, and bars extend this immersion with confidence. From historically rooted dining to Patiala Peg's celebration of a uniquely Indian drinking legacy, the hotel doesn't reference history, it commits to it. Service is warm and personal; you're addressed by name, remembered across spaces. The spa is a Mughal suite that feels like an ancient hammam. The Akoi family has owned it independently since the 1930s, resisting acquisition, which gives it a family-run warmth most luxury chains simply can't replicate.

Three Michelin Keys: Taj Lake Palace, Udaipur
Floating in Lake Pichola, reachable only by boat, the 18th-Century palace feels unreal. Originally a royal summer palace, the Lake Palace is an extraordinary amalgamation of Mughal, Rajasthani, and European influences. Almost every room faces the lake; those that don't, overlook tranquil gardens. Dining environments are spectacular, though the food – while excellent – does not quite match the setting's grandeur. More than a hotel, the Lake Palace is a living heritage site. Its preservation sustains local livelihoods and safeguards a floating architectural marvel. Would I pay around ₹95,000 a night to feel like a maharaja? Absolutely. This is a definitive Three-Key property – perhaps beyond.

STEP OUT



Botanical memories
Flowers, plants and childhood objects become carriers of memory and identity in Aishwaryan K's *Where the Flowers Keep Their Counsel*. The artist's drawings explore botanical forms, play, everyday life and queer experience through spare compositions. Curated by Satyajit Dave, the exhibition marks his first solo show in Delhi NCR. *On from August 22 to September 15, at Gallerie Splash, Gurgaon.*



Sacred stage
Fifty years after its debut, *Krishna* returns for the Janmashtami season, tracing the deity's journey from Gokul to Kurukshetra through dance, music and theatre. The production is directed by Shobha Deepak Singh. *At Kamani Auditorium from August 29 to September 4. Tickets at ₹300 on BookMyShow.*

In new shades

The hotel art fair returns to New Delhi for its fifth edition, with emerging artists

Geetika Sachdev

Art fairs traditionally bring galleries and artists together in large halls, with visitors moving from one booth to another. Artix has taken a different route. Since 2023, the fair has used hotel rooms as exhibition spaces. Five editions later, the format has become central to Artix's identity. The upcoming edition, to be held at The Claridges, New Delhi, on August 22 and 23, will feature 20 selected participants across 21 rooms. The lineup includes Lotus Arts de Vivre, 108 Art Projects, Golf Green Gallery, Aura Art Gallery, Gallery Vision Art, Jagat Jewels, Arushi Arts, Taranaksh, Bharati Shah, Aanchal Garg and Art & You, spanning art, design, jewellery, textiles, fashion and craft. For founders Malvika Poddar and Payal Kapoor, the emphasis on younger artists and collectors has developed over the course of the fair's editions. "We found that we have one niche we got into, which was young collectors and young artists," says Malvika. Payal, who runs Arushi Arts, says the economics of larger fairs can make it difficult for galleries to take risks on emerging practitioners. The selection process is nevertheless closely filtered.

Applications are reviewed by a committee, with portfolios, resumes and previous work considered before participants are chosen. A new Artist in Focus section brings together five distinct practices. Gauri Verma explores the human form through sculpture, while Eknoor Matharoo works across printmaking, illustration and bookmaking. Divya Kumar uses everyday objects as the basis for playful interpretations of familiar spaces, while Tania Verma creates acrylic abstracts informed by ideas of spiritual and emotional transformation. The youngest participant, 12-year-old Shanayya Kapoor, brings a youthful perspective to the presentation. The initiative will sit alongside a dedicated showcase of works by the late KG Subramanyan, bringing an important figure from Indian modern art into the same setting as contemporary artists. The programme will include panel discussions and guided walkthroughs, with conversations around art, collecting, design and culture. After Delhi, Artix will move to Mumbai in February 2027.

Artix 5.0 will be held on August 22 and 23, from 11am to 8pm, at The Claridges, New Delhi. Entry is free.



Modern art
Artwork by artist Aanchal Garg. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Mountains of flavour (Clockwise from left) Vivek Man Sherchan, owner of Jimbu Thakali; interiors of the Delhi restaurant; and Mustang potatoes. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Beyond the momo

Jimbu Thakali's first restaurant in India brings the food of Nepal's Mustang region to Gurgaon

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury
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Delhi has become synonymous with a seemingly endless parade of increasingly questionable variations on the momo, as though Nepal's vast culinary heritage begins and ends with a dumpling stuffed with whatever new abomination Delhiites currently find exciting. Very few restaurants in the city have attempted to engage with the breadth of Nepali food beyond momos, and fewer still have managed to present it with an authenticity. To address that gap, one of the country's popular restaurant chains has finally opened its doors in Delhi-NCR: Jimbu Thakali, a Kathmandu-born chain devoted to the cuisine of Nepal's Thakali community.

Vivek Man Sherchan is the hospitality entrepreneur behind Jimbu, which began in Kathmandu in 2016 and now has four outlets across Nepal. When the devastating 2015 earthquake forced him to reconsider the business, the restaurant that emerged from that disruption eventually became Jimbu Thakali. "I decided, when in Rome, you know?" Vivek tells me. "What's the most popular palate in Nepal?" His answer was the food people were already eating at home, particularly rice-based meals served with vegetables, dal and an assortment of accompaniments.

"The Thakali thali is basically a staple," he says. "It is something that the average Nepali household consumes almost every day." Jimbu's version developed around the idea that families could eat the food they knew while enjoying the convenience of eating out. Thakali cuisine itself comes from the Thak Khola region of Mustang, where the Thakali community historically lived along the Kali Gandaki trade corridor. Mustang's altitude shaped what could be cultivated, while its position along trade routes brought outside ingredients and culinary influences into the region. Buckwheat became particularly important, while jimbu, timur and fermented foods acquired distinctive roles in the cuisine. The Mustang-spiced potatoes are among the simplest things I ate, and perhaps the easiest to underestimate. The



mushroom choila was another favourite, served cold and coated in Newari spices that give the mushrooms a sharp, acidic edge against their chilled texture. The mutton momos are more immediately familiar, although their appeal comes from the effort behind the chilling and seasoning rather than novelty. But the highlight for me was the cheli jwai Thali, named after the Nepali term for a son-in-law. The idea, as Vivek explains, is that "when the son-in-law comes home, you pamper him with an extravagant meal". Sherchan attributes much of Jimbu's culinary identity to his mother, whose recipes form the foundation of the Thakali menu. "Our entire Thakali menu is based on my mom's recipes," he says. With a history this curious baked into its walls, Jimbu Thakali definitely feels like a new culinary homestyle experience worth seeking out, especially if you're ready to move beyond Delhi's momo obsession and taste the Nepal that exists beyond the dumpling.

Jimbu Thakali is at M3M 65th Avenue, Gurgaon. A meal for two costs approximately ₹2,000. Open for lunch and dinner.



Trial by fire

West Bengal should rebuild its crumbling, hazardous infrastructure

What is it with West Bengal and fires? Since 2025, there have been major fires, in hotels and in godowns, claiming some 65 lives, many of them poor and migrant workers and pilgrims. The State seems to be an egregious case of the generally poor fire safety record of Indian factories, industrial facilities as well as cities and towns built on top of greed, a disregard for laws, corruption, and scant respect for lives and property. The Shikha Inn was housed in a century-old building on Mirza Ghalib Street in Kolkata, which apparently had several hotels – on each of its five floors. It was obviously not built to be a hotel. Shikha Inn is typical of what happens in India, where old buildings with electrical systems designed for a certain load are quickly repurposed, and modern equipment is added without any consideration of whether the system can handle the air-conditioners, washing machines, heaters and induction stoves. The August 17 fire in Tarapith was apparently electrical too and the killer was the smoke. The fire spread rapidly because the pilgrim hotel used flammable materials extensively. Rituraj Hotel, which caught fire in April 2025, had also been repurposed. With just one stairway, the fire on the first floor cut off escape, and, just as in the Mirza Ghalib Street fire, smoke trapped those above.

For the new BJP government in West Bengal, the accidents have provided more fodder for its attacks on the TMC. Though Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari called the Kolkata fire “impossible to ignore”, he nevertheless blamed a “legacy of negligence”. This may well be true but serves little purpose. The present government has, similar to its predecessor, a dedicated Fire Minister. There have been promises of robust action such as a Statewide safety audit, but the focus seems to be more on the TMC than on corrective action. Mr. Adhikari should dismount the campaign horse and look at the elephant in the room – crumbling infrastructure. In its first 100 days, the government has been rather silent on the creaky infrastructure of West Bengal – a State with a rich history of urban life, industrialisation, culture and progressive politics that once led the nation, but now lags behind much of India in roads, buildings, amenities and governance. Urban renewal is the stock-in-trade of the BJP across India and West Bengal will be well served by a State BJP that adopts it. Heritage buildings and conservation have their own value, including for tourism, but require careful planning to suit today’s needs. Mr. Adhikari should place governance above petty politics and focus on infrastructure.

Socialist surge

Affordability issues propel democratic socialists in the United States

As the Trump administration persists with its blunderbuss reshaping of American foreign policy – a marriage of hyperimperialism, with wars in West Asia, a de facto capture of power in Venezuela and the strangling of Cuba’s fuel trade, and isolationism, seen in withdrawals from multilateral institutions and tariffs imposed on a whim – the world has been waiting for a political alternative to Trumpism to take shape. After 2024, when a vapid Democratic Party displayed little ideological gumption on foreign policy, welfare or taking on the plutocrats reshaping American democracy, the prospects looked slim. Then, in November 2025, Zohran Mamdani won New York City on a platform of de-commodification – placing citizens’ needs above market shibboleths – while openly calling Israel’s war on Gaza a genocide. His victory did more than capture New York’s imagination. It set off an insurgency by democratic socialists within Democratic Party ranks. In Michigan’s August 4 primary, Abdul El-Sayed, a progressive backed by Independent Senator Bernie Sanders, won the Democratic nomination for the Senate despite pro-Israel groups spending heavily against him. Angie Nixon, a three-term State legislator who joined the Democratic Socialists of America in June, has won Florida’s Democratic Senate nomination, having spent merely \$60,000 on advertising as opposed to her moderate opponent’s \$2.2 million. Such results matter in a country where socialism has been used to evoke the Red Scare, even decades after the Cold War.

Mr. Sanders, whose unabashed democratic socialism is closer to European social democracy than to state ownership of the means of production, ran two presidential campaigns that prepared this ground while the likes of Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez and others showed its electoral viability in Democratic strongholds in House elections. In 2026, a new generation of democratic socialists has sharpened its methods and its reach. The focus on affordability in childcare, rent freeze, Medicare for All and taxing the rich while breaking with the Democratic Party’s foreign policy consensus, including on funding Israel’s military, has carried them beyond strongholds such as New York. The new cohort has not only won primaries but also registered a shift in the political outlook of many Americans. But caution is warranted. Taking on the Republican machine in November will be a far tougher task, especially if the Democratic establishment does not rally around its insurgents against Trumpism. Yet, supporters point to a deeply unpopular Mr. Trump, and a welfare-first message that could cut across the U.S.’s culture wars the Republicans will keep stoking. For the Global South, including Indians, the rise of democratic socialism as a viable force in the U.S. will be welcome, as its emphasis rests on fair trade and multilateral engagement, besides an end to Washington’s forever wars.

Geopolitical headwinds in the background of recently introduced tax changes would shape the Centre’s fiscal outlook for 2026-27. Despite pressure on tax revenues and subsidies, strong non-tax receipts and policy interventions may keep fiscal outcomes broadly on track.

Centre’s revenue receipts

As per the The Controller General of Accounts (CGA) data, the Centre’s gross tax revenues (GTR) grew only by 3.7% in the first quarter of 2026-27. This was the result of subdued revenue performance of personal income tax (PIT) and Goods and Services Tax (GST), both of which were subjected to substantive modifications in 2025-26. In both cases, extensive rate rationalisation was undertaken. In the case of GST, there was a substantive rate reduction. The expectation was that while these reforms would entail an initial revenue sacrifice, subsequent expansion of the tax base would offset the revenue loss over time. PIT revenue growth in 2025-26 was only 0.037%, implying a buoyancy of zero. For the second half of 2025-26, GST revenue growth was 4.67%. The revenue reducing effect of these major tax interventions has continued in 2026-27. PIT shows a growth of 6.8% in the first quarter of 2026-27 while GST revenues showed a contraction of (-)11%.

In the meantime, the Indian economy was beset by the West Asian crisis and its related impact, including high and volatile global crude oil prices and other supply-side uncertainties. As retail fuel prices rose, the government reduced excise duties to ease the burden on consumers. This had a direct bearing on revenue from Union excise duties, which contracted by 22.4% in the first quarter of 2026-27.

In order to make up for the shortfall in revenue receipts, the government initiated some remedial measures. First, a Health Security se National Security (HSNS) Cess was introduced with effect from February 1, 2026 even as the GST Compensation Cess was discontinued. Second, the windfall tax on exports of diesel, petrol and aviation turbine fuel was increased effective August 3, 2026. Third, there was an increase in



C. Rangarajan

Former Chairman, Prime Minister’s Economic Advisory Council and former Governor, Reserve Bank of India



D.K. Srivastava

Member, Advisory Council to the Sixteenth Finance Commission and former Director of the Madras School of Economics

Central government finances for 2026-27 may remain close to budgeted levels

import duties through increased rates on gold and silver bullion and other specific precious metal articles, sweepings, and clad metals. One additional factor is the likelihood of a higher nominal GDP growth rate as compared to the budgeted growth of 10.04%. We expect the 2026-27 nominal GDP growth to be in the range of 12.5% to 13%. This projection reflects an expected real GDP growth of about 7% together with an Implicit Price Deflator (IPD)-based inflation of 5%-5.5%, consistent with the present trajectories of Consumer Price Index (CPI) and Wholesale Price Index (WPI) inflation at 3.9% and 9.3%, respectively, in the first quarter of 2026-27. We note that even with a higher nominal GDP growth rate, the magnitude of nominal GDP as per the 2022-23 base series is estimated at ₹391 lakh crore. This will be lower than the budgeted level at ₹393 lakh crore. On the whole, we consider that the estimated GTR would be realised or fall short by a small margin. At some suitable time, the reduction in excise duty on fuel prices must be restored.

Transfers to States

In estimating net tax revenue from GTR, a factor of 65%, which was the ratio of net to gross tax revenues in 2025-26 and 2026-27 (BE), can be applied since the Sixteenth Finance Commission (FC16) retained the share of States in the divisible pool of central taxes at 41%. There may be a marginal reduction in the shareable pool due to the introduction of the non-shareable HSNS Cess although some part of the revenues from this cess may go to the States as non-FC grants.

In the first quarter of 2026-27, there was a sharp contraction in tax devolution to the States to the extent of (-)19.5%. In subsequent months, there is an expectation of an increase in the assignment of central tax revenues to the States. Based on the FC16’s recommendation, the FC grants for the States are budgeted to contract by an amount of ₹23,556 crore in 2026-27.

The Reserve Bank of India provided major fiscal support in the form of dividends, which were transferred to the Centre in May 2026. As a result, 77% of the budgeted dividends and profits for the full year had already been covered in the

first three months. We expect the budgeted amounts for non-tax and non-debt capital receipts to be realised.

The Centre’s non-tax revenues contributed 37% of its net revenue receipts in the first quarter of 2026-27. During the quarter, major subsidies had to be increased by 37.4% due to the unexpected rise in global crude oil prices, although the growth in revenue expenditure was contained at 7.4%. The Centre was able to front-load its capital expenditure in the first quarter of 2026-27, which grew by 23.7%, compared with a contraction of (-)23.3% in the fourth quarter of 2025-26.

For the year as a whole, the crisis in West Asia is likely to continue keeping global crude oil prices under pressure. If the major subsidies in the first quarter are extrapolated to estimate the annual subsidy requirement, realised subsidies are expected to exceed the budgeted amount by about ₹50,000 crore.

Debt and deficit

Using first-quarter data, the Centre’s fiscal deficit accounted for 18.2% of the annual budgeted magnitude, while the corresponding share of the revenue deficit was 0.4%. The impressive revenue account balance is mainly due to the contribution of non-debt receipts.

Fiscal deficit, calculated as the increment in debt, is estimated at ₹18.16 lakh crore. If this is realised, the fiscal deficit-to-GDP ratio, with respect to the new GDP series, is estimated at 4.6%. Correspondingly, the debt-to-GDP ratio is estimated at 55.8%. This is close to the budgeted level, taking into account the impact of the new GDP series. Some slippage may still occur due to a shortfall in tax revenues, an unbudgeted increase in revenue expenditure arising from additional subsidies, and a slightly higher external debt amid sustained pressure on the Indian rupee. As of now, significant deviations from the budgeted fiscal outcomes appear unlikely. However, an escalation of the war could deliver a major jolt to the economy and central finances.

The views expressed are personal

The Vanashakti verdict is balanced and pragmatic

The Supreme Court of India’s landmark judgment delivered on July 29, 2026 in *Vanashakti vs Union of India* has brought much-needed clarity to one of the most debated issues in environmental regulation: the fate of projects that commenced without obtaining prior Environmental Clearance (EC).

Wider policy impact

While the judgment firmly reiterates that obtaining prior EC is a mandatory legal requirement under the Environment Impact Assessment Notification (EIA) Notification, 2006, it also provides an important policy direction that could have far-reaching implications for thousands of industries, infrastructure projects and real estate developments across India.

The Court has categorically held that project proponents who commenced construction or operations without obtaining prior EC and that did not apply under the earlier violation mechanisms, cannot now seek regularisation under the 2017 Notification or the 2021 Standard Operating Procedure (Office Memorandum). Those mechanisms are no longer available for fresh cases.

At first glance, this may appear to shut the door completely on pending violation projects. However, a closer reading of the judgment reveals a far more balanced and pragmatic approach. One of the most significant aspects is the Court’s recognition that the central government continues to possess the statutory power under Section 3 of the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986 to frame a fresh statutory mechanism for dealing with violation cases, if considered necessary in the larger public interest.

The Court has made an important distinction between an administrative office memorandum, which cannot override the requirement of prior EC, and a statutory notification issued under the powers conferred by the Environment (Protection) Act. While the former has been held to be legally unsustainable, the latter remains a permissible legislative option, provided it is



Kalaiselvan Periyasamy

Environmental and social expert

The top court’s verdict closes existing environmental clearance regularisation routes while leaving scope for a new framework

carefully designed within the framework of environmental law.

This observation is likely to have significant policy implications. Across India, numerous industrial units, commercial developments, infrastructure projects and public utility projects remain in violation of the EC requirements for various reasons. Some projects proceeded due to regulatory uncertainty, others due to an incorrect interpretation of the law, while some simply failed to obtain the necessary approvals before commencement. Many such projects never applied under the earlier violation windows and have therefore been left without a legal pathway following the closure of the 2017 scheme and the striking down of the 2021 Office Memorandum.

The present judgment acknowledges this practical reality without compromising the fundamental principle that prior EC remains mandatory.

Where there is a balancing act

Importantly, the Court has not directed the central government to introduce a new regularisation scheme. Instead, it has clarified that the government may, if it considers it necessary, in the larger public interest, issue a fresh statutory notification providing a one-time opportunity for specified categories of violation projects.

The Court has also indicated the safeguards that such a notification must incorporate. Any future scheme cannot become a permanent “violate first, regularise later” mechanism. Instead, it should be strictly one-time, supported by statutory authority, and should include comprehensive environmental safeguards such as environmental damage assessment, remediation measures, environmental compensation and strict compliance conditions.

This balanced approach attempts to reconcile two equally important objectives. On one hand, environmental laws cannot encourage deliberate violations by allowing routine post-facto approvals, while on the other, indiscriminate

closure or demolition of every violation project may not always serve either environmental protection or the larger public interest, particularly where projects are otherwise environmentally acceptable and substantial investments have already been made.

The judgment therefore reinforces the principle that environmental governance should combine strict enforcement with practical and scientifically sound regulatory solutions.

For project developers, industries and infrastructure agencies, the immediate message is straightforward. No fresh applications can now be made under the earlier violation mechanisms. However, the judgment also leaves open the possibility that the central government may formulate a fresh statutory framework to address pending violation cases in an environmentally responsible manner.

The regulatory road ahead

Whether such a policy initiative will be undertaken now rests entirely with the central government. Given the large number of pending projects across various sectors, industry associations, infrastructure developers, environmental professionals and other stakeholders are expected to closely watch the government’s next steps. The judgment has effectively closed the old regulatory route but has simultaneously acknowledged that Parliament’s environmental legislation still provides sufficient statutory authority for a carefully structured one-time solution, should the government consider such intervention necessary.

The July 2026 judgment is therefore significant not merely because it settles the legal validity of earlier violation mechanisms, but also because it charts the contours of any future policy on environmental regularisation. It preserves the integrity of the prior EC regime while leaving sufficient legislative space for the government to address genuine legacy violations through a lawful, transparent, and environmentally robust statutory framework.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The goal as good doctors

All necessary security measures should be put in place, at least from now on, so that paper leaks, court hearings, protests, administrative decisions, demands for accountability and the like become a thing of the past. While healthy competition, even if stiff, is welcome, it is unfair to subject medical aspirants to such teething troubles even before they make their deep medical plunge through the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate), which is supposed to be the ultimate test of their merit and mettle. There should be no scope for man-made manipulations that enable non-meritorious candidates

to find shortcuts to becoming doctors and entering the profession. One can well imagine the adverse consequences of unworthy and undeserving persons becoming doctors and treating the public. Let us turn a new page and focus on producing good doctors.

R. Sampath, Chennai

Perks, misplaced priorities

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay’s recent announcement to provide brand-new luxury cars and a monthly vehicle allowance of ₹75,000, plus additional staffing perks to all 234 MLAs is a staggering display of misplaced priorities. The vast majority

of the elected representatives already own multiple personal vehicles or have ample logistical means. Handing out luxury State perks and unconditional monthly cash flows to affluent politicians while ordinary citizens struggle with inflation, crumbling local infrastructure, and unmet basic welfare needs shows a shocking disconnect from ground realities. To spend crores of taxpayer money on luxury upgrades for sitting politicians, under the guise of helping “humble backgrounds”, is an insult to the public (“All T.N. MLAs to get car and assistant for constituency work”, August 20). At a time when the State treasury must be

guarded and prioritised for public health, education, and employment generation, spending crores of rupees on redundant vehicular luxuries for lawmakers is fiscally reckless. Public money belongs to the public, not to the comfort of already-privileged politicians.

R. Sivakumar, Chennai

Word ‘industry’ redefined

A substantial portion of Justice V.R. Krishna Iyer’s judgment has been preserved for all pending disputes. The majority has held that the triple-test theory requires reconsideration. At the heart of the controversy,

however, is Justice Krishna Iyer’s judgment and the philosophy that informed it. It is a matter of some relief that his broad-based judgment, which provided a forum for the working class, has been preserved for pending litigation. It is unfortunate, however, that the benefit of this liberal approach has not been extended to the millions of toiling workers for whom Justice Krishna Iyer was a beacon of hope. It is also refreshing that Justice B.V. Nagarathna has upheld the principles enunciated by Justice Krishna Iyer in the Bangalore Water Supply case and held that the reference itself was unnecessary. At the same time, one must take note of

the damage caused by the definition of “industry” under the Industrial Relations Code. The Code adopts a highly conservative definition that excludes a number of activities, thereby leaving sections of the working class vulnerable and without adequate legal protection. This is a moment for the working class to organise rather than depend on legislative prescriptions or judicial interpretations for their survival, dignity and progress. The battle lines have been drawn.

N.G.R. Prasad, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

THE HINDU

14.91 in ₹ crore.
Maharashtra has approved ₹14.91 crore for installing Internet of Things (IoT)-based fire alarm systems at 24 regional transport offices and deputy RTOs across the State. PTI

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KEYWORD

Beyond blasphemy: how laws can curtail the possibility of social reform

Section 295A and similar laws have been used against writers, artists and reformers, with arrest, threats and pre-emptive censorship often causing harm before trial; their coexistence with laws targeting regressive religious practices exposes the lack of a coherent approach to religious sentiment

Prathmesh Kher

The history of Section 295A and its cousins shows how easily laws meant to prevent communal violence have instead been turned against the critique of regressive or simply unconventional religious practice. In 1932, a small collection of Urdu short stories called *Angarey*, which attacked obscurantist customs and the sexual hypocrisy of some religious figures, was banned soon after publication, and its authors faced threats. Seven Indian States banned the film and book *The Da Vinci Code* in 2006 on the ground that it offended Christian sentiment, a ban two States later lifted only after High Court intervention.

More recent cases show the pattern continuing under a veneer of literary and scholarly respectability. Wendy Doniger's *The Hindus: An Alternative History* was withdrawn by Penguin India in 2014 after a civil suit invoking Section 295A. Tamil novelist Perumal Murugan faced a criminal complaint and a mob campaign over his novel *Madhorubagan*; he announced his own “death” as a writer in 2015 rather than face continued harassment. It took a landmark 2016 Madras High Court judgment, which closed with the appeal to “let the author be resurrected to what he is best at, write,” to quash the case and restore his right to publish. The painter M.F. Husain was hounded into exile and death abroad after decades of prosecutions and threats over his nude depictions of Hindu deities. Taslima Nasrin's writing has met similar treatment, and the government's 1988 ban on importing Salman Rushdie's *The Satanic Verses* made India one of the first countries, a secular one at that, in the world to act against that novel.

The provision has, if anything, found new life in the era of social media and televised debate, where the underlying act being punished has grown thinner still. In 2018, weeks after the Supreme Court lifted the traditional ban on women of menstruating age entering the Sabarimala temple, the Kerala activist Rehana Fathima was arrested under Section 295A over a Facebook photograph of herself dressed as an Ayyappa devotee, spent over two weeks in judicial custody, and was suspended by her employer within days of her arrest, all over an image rather than an argument. In 2020, the television anchor Amish Devgan called the Sufi saint Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti a ‘*lootera*’ during a live debate, apologised within days for what he said was an inadvertent slip for a different historical name, and still faced seven separate FIRs across five States; the Supreme Court declined to quash any of them, merely clubbing them together in Ajmer. These cases rarely end in conviction; more often the prosecution goes nowhere. What unites them is that the damage is done well before any verdict, through arrest, through the heckler's veto of an aggressive, sometimes violent audience, and through the pre-emptive caution of publishers and film certifiers who calculate, reasonably, that no book or film is worth the trouble.

The other direction

It would be unfair to the complexity of Indian law, to present this as a single uninterrupted march towards religious censorship. India also has statutes that go



GETTY IMAGES

the other way, actively empowering the State to attack religious or superstitious practice, and the constitutional foundation for this other tendency was laid before the Constitution had even been adopted. Speaking in the Constituent Assembly on December 2, 1948, during the debate on whether personal law should be shielded from legislative reform, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar rejected the idea that religion could claim a veto over social legislation merely because a given custom carried religious sanction. “I personally do not understand why religion should be given this vast, expansive jurisdiction so as to cover the whole of life and to prevent the legislature from encroaching upon that field... We are having this liberty in order to reform our social system... It is, therefore, quite impossible for anybody to conceive that the personal law shall be excluded from the jurisdiction of the State,” Dr. Ambedkar said.

Maharashtra's Prevention and Eradication of Human Sacrifice and Other Inhuman, Evil and Aghori Practices and Black Magic Act, passed in 2013 after the assassination of the rationalist campaigner Narendra Dabholkar, criminalises a long list of exploitative religious practices, from claiming to cure disease through faith healing to inducing self-flagellation. Karnataka passed a similar law in 2017. The Sati (Prevention) Act of 1987 goes further still, criminalising

not only the act of widow immolation but the glorification of it, treating celebratory speech about a religious practice as itself an offence, the mirror image of a blasphemy law rather than its opposite.

The coexistence of these two tendencies, laws that punish criticism of religion and laws that mandate criticism of religious practice, suggests that Indian law has no coherent theory of when religious sentiment deserves protection. What actually governs is a case-by-case political calculation about which practices are currently unpopular enough, or which constituencies are currently powerful enough, to tip the balance one way or the other.

The reformer as blasphemer

The starkest illustration of what this body of law puts at risk is not the outsider mocking a faith he does not share, but the insider attacking his own. In *The State of Mysore versus Henry Rodrigues*, decided by the Mysore High Court in 1961, a Catholic editor named Henry Rodrigues was tried under Section 295A over an article in his Konkani-language magazine *Crusader*, titled “*Honour to Mary or Dishonour?*”, which accused Catholic priests of exploiting the credulous by falsely attributing miracles to the Virgin Mary. His defence argued that since the criticised beliefs and practices were, in his view, superstitious and contrary to the Bible itself, the truth of his charge ought

to absolve him. The court, following an earlier Allahabad High Court ruling, rejected this outright: even a wholly true statement, it held, can outrage religious feelings, and Section 295A punishes the intent to outrage rather than the accuracy of what is said. A believer's sincere, internally argued complaint against his own clergy was treated exactly as the law treats a stranger's contempt.

The doctrine that truth is no defence is what should give the sharpest pause to anyone tempted to think of a blasphemy law as merely a shield against bigotry. India's own history is built on reformers who succeeded only because they were prepared to be called blasphemers by their own people. Jyotirao Phule spent the 1870s attacking Brahminical religious authority as the theological scaffolding of caste oppression, recasting Hindu myth in his tract *Gulamgiri* to expose it as a device for keeping the lower castes subjugated. A century later, Hamid Dalwai founded the Muslim Satyashodhak Mandal explicitly on Phule's model, marched a handful of Muslim women to the Maharashtra Assembly to demand an end to triple talaq and polygamy, and was ostracised and abused for it. Neither man set out to comfort the pious. Both set out to unsettle them, because unsettling belief is what the reform of belief requires; it is not hard to imagine how a modern Section 299 complaint, or a Punjab-style sacrilege charge over their treatment of scripture and tradition, would read against language of that kind.

A law that criminalises the “deliberate and malicious” intention to outrage religious feeling, read honestly rather than sympathetically, does not obviously distinguish a Phule or a Dalwai from a bigot baiting a rival faith for sport: both are, in the plainest sense, trying to make believers feel bad about what they believe. What should separate them, in any society that values reform as much as it values sentiment, is whether the critic is trying to improve the community or merely humiliate it, a distinction that a police station taking down a complaint is poorly placed to draw.

Limits of protection

Supporters of laws like Punjab's have an argument, and it deserves to be engaged with rather than waved off. India is a country where religious sentiment has repeatedly proved combustible. A targeted law, applied with judicial restraint and the safeguard of proven intent, could in principle be a proportionate response to that risk rather than an assault on free thought.

The historical record of Section 295A, and now of Punjab's own sacrilege law, gives little confidence that restraint is what actually happens in practice.

A secular Constitution that permits the state to imprison people for life over an insult to a book, however sacred, has conceded more ground to religious authority than its own founding principle allows. If India wishes to remain true to the secularism its Constitution declares unamendable, the honest path is to narrow these provisions to their original, defensible purpose: preventing incitement to actual violence, and leave the criticism, satire and reform of religious practice, however uncomfortable, to public argument rather than to the criminal courts. *(This concludes the three-part series)*



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

“What is the matter with you?”
“I have been thinking about our Indian cricket team. I feel absolutely miserable whenever they lose.”
“Don't eat your heart out about a bunch of overpaid underachievers!”
“Eat my heart out?”
“When you tell someone not to ‘eat his heart out’ about something or someone, you are telling him not to grieve or feel sad about something or someone.”
“Sumithran has been eating his heart out ever since his neighbour sold her house and moved to another town.”
“My cousin Anuradha ate her heart out when she was forced to sell her grandmother's diamonds.”
“Our team didn't win. But don't eat your heart out.”
“That should be the attitude. By the way, the expression, ‘eat your heart out’ has another meaning as well. It can mean, ‘to be jealous’.”
“I see. How about this example? When my friend heard that I had won twenty lakhs in a lottery, he ate his heart out.”
“That's good. Do you think you will ever win twenty lakhs in a lottery?”
“Who knows? Some day fate may decide to smile on me.”
“It already has. That's why you have a friend like me! Anyway, here's another example. Look you guys; these five new cars belong to me. So eat your heart out.”
“That's a nasty thing to say.”
“I know! And you know what the sad part is? I'll never get a chance to say something like that in real life.”
“Thank god for that. By the way, I've started taking tennis lessons. Hewitt, eat your heart out. How does that sound?”
“You expect Hewitt to be jealous because you have started playing tennis?”
“Yes, because pretty soon I will be beating him!”
“Keep dreaming. I don't think the fact that you are learning tennis is going to eat away at Hewitt.”
“Eat away at Hewitt?”
“When something ‘eats away at someone’ or ‘eats at someone’, it troubles or worries the person. This is one of the meanings of the expression.”
“The terrible state of the company was eating away at Raju.”
“Vinita's financial problems ate away at her day and night.”
“Vinita has financial problems? But I thought she was very rich.”
“Her father is very rich, that's true.”
“.... so why doesn't she ask her father for some money?”
“Are you crazy? He'll eat her out.”
“He'll eat her out? The expression probably means to scold someone severely. Am I right?”
“I am impressed. Can you give me an example?”
“The Principal ate the teacher out and put the fear of God into her.”
“Didn't the other teachers protest?”
“That was just an example. The Principal that we have now is too timid to eat anyone out.”
“The coach ate the player out for playing an irresponsible shot.”
“When the students walked in half an hour late, the Professor really ate them out.”
“That was a good example. By the way, how did you guess the meaning of ‘eat someone out’?”
“Well, ‘eat someone out’ sounds like ‘chew someone out’. And I know that ‘chew someone out’ means to scold someone.”
“Very good.”
Published in The Hindu on September 18, 2001

THE DAILY QUIZ

Here is a quiz on Bajirao I, the Maratha Peshwa whose swift campaigns reshaped 18th-century India

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1
Which Maratha ruler appointed Bajirao I as Peshwa in 1720?

QUESTION 2
Bajirao I is particularly associated with which form of warfare, relying on speed, mobility and cavalry rather than slow, set-piece engagements?

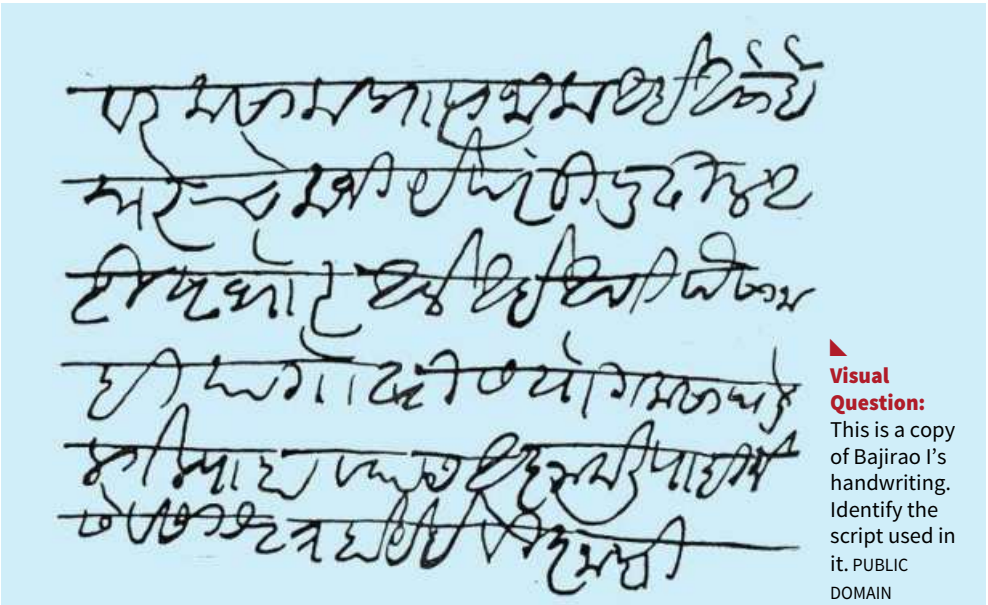
QUESTION 3
Which Bundela ruler sought Bajirao's assistance against the

Mughal commander Muhammad Khan Bangash?

QUESTION 4
Which battle of December 1737 saw Bajirao confront the Nizam and allied Mughal forces near a fortified town?

QUESTION 5
Bajirao died in 1740 on the banks of which major river?

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. When was the competition first held? **Ans: 1991**
2. Where was the inaugural



Visual Question: This is a copy of Bajirao I's handwriting. Identify the script used in it. **PUBLIC DOMAIN**

tournament held? **Ans: China**
3. Which country has won the tournament the maximum number of times? **Ans: USA**
4. Which country is scheduled to host the 2027 edition? **Ans: Brazil**
5. Starting from which year will the number of finalists once again increase from 32 to 48? **Ans: 2031**
Visual: In this image, which team won the 2019 FIFA Women's World Cup title? **Ans: USA**
Early Birds: Dil Bahadur Airee | Varghese Joseph | Sadhan Panda | Monika Sinha | Prabhat Kumar

Word of the day

Diatribes: thunderous verbal attack

Synonyms: tirade, attack, rant, criticism

Usage: *She went on a diatribe about bad customer service.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/diatribe

International Phonetic Alphabet: /daɪəˈtrɪb/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

CMYK M ND-NDE

Sajjan Kumar, convict in anti-Sikh riots case, dies

Former Cong. MP had been in custody since Dec 2018, when he surrendered after HC overturned his acquittal in case relating to killing of five members of a Sikh family and burning of a gurdwara

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Sajjan Kumar, a three-term Lok Sabha member and a once-powerful leader of the Delhi Congress, whose political career was eclipsed by his conviction in the 1984 anti-Sikh riots cases, died at Safdarjung Hospital here on Thursday. He was 80.

Kumar, who was serving a life sentence in Tihar Jail, was taken to hospital after his health deteriorated and was declared brought dead. He had been in custody since December 2018, when the Delhi High Court overturned his acquittal in a case relating to the killing of five members of a Sikh family and the burning of a gurdwara.

His death has left the Congress with a political dilemma ahead of the Punjab Assembly election. The party's top leadership has maintained a conspicuous silence on his death, with no immediate condolences. Pawan Khera, chair-



Former Congress MP Sajjan Kumar leaving the Karkardooma Court after appearing in an anti-Sikh riots case in 2010. FILE PHOTO

man of the Congress's media and publicity department, was among the only prominent party functionaries to publicly condole the death, expressing sympathy to Kumar's family. Delhi Congress chief Devender Yadav also expressed sorrow, describing the death as "heartbreaking".

Born in 1945, Kumar began his political career through the Congress organisation and was elected a councillor to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi in 1977. He subsequently became general secretary of

the Delhi Pradesh Congress Committee and emerged as a powerful organiser in the capital. He was associated with the political network around Sanjay Gandhi. He entered the Lok Sabha from Outer Delhi in 1980. He was elected again in 1991 and 2004, making him a three-term MP. His political career, however, came under scrutiny over allegations relating to the 1984 violence.

The violence, which erupted after Prime Minister Indira Gandhi was assassinated by her Sikh bodyguards on October 31,

1984, resulted in a massacre of Sikhs in retaliatory attacks across the country, with Delhi accounting for the largest number of deaths. Kumar was accused of leading and instigating mobs during the violence. A trial court acquitted him in 2013 in a case concerning the killing of five Sikh men and the burning of a gurdwara in Delhi. The Delhi High Court overturned the acquittal in December 2018 and convicted him of criminal conspiracy, abetment and other offences, sentencing him to imprisonment for the remainder of his natural life. He resigned from the Congress a day after the verdict and surrendered before the authorities.

A second conviction followed in February 2025, when a Delhi court sentenced him to life imprisonment for the killing of Jaswant Singh and his son Tarundeep Singh, who were burned alive during the violence.

Amit Shah slams Congress's decision to render only two stanzas of Vande Mataram

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday launched a sharp attack on the Congress, alleging that its decision to render only the first two stanzas of *Vande Mataram* reflected appeasement politics, disrespected martyrs and undermined national unity.

In a statement to the media, Mr. Shah termed the Congress Working Committee's move on Wednesday to feature only the first two stanzas of *Vande Mataram* at party functions, in line with the All India Congress Committee resolution of 1937, as "anti-national".

"I want to remind the entire country that in 1937, the Congress party, for the sake of Muslim appeasement, split *Vande Mataram* into two pieces, laying the foundation for the country's Partition, and from there, the two-nation theory gained strength. Ultimately, the country was partitioned, and Pakistan was born," Mr. Shah said.



Amit Shah

The "historic mistake" was corrected in the 150th year of the emergence of the National Song by the Narendra Modi government, in an effort to "strengthen national integration by singing Bankim babu's (Bankim Chandra Chatterjee) immortal creation in full".

"For the sake of vote banks, they have not only disrespected Bankim babu's immortal creation but also insulted those millions of martyrs who went to the gallows for the country's freedom," he said.

The BJP said it would forcefully oppose the Congress's decision before the people as well as in the legislative Houses. "When, just a few days ago, this same insult had been exposed in the conduct of an individual, the Congress had dismissed it as a coincidence. Today, that very insult has become the Congress's policy," BJP president Nitin Nabin said on X, in a reference to a gesture by Congress leader Sonia Gandhi during a rendition of the song on August 15.

'BJP diverting attention' The Congress hit back at Mr. Shah. The party's communication chief, Jairam Ramesh, termed BJP leaders as "fraudulent and fake nationalists" and accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Mr. Shah of diverting attention from their failures in dealing with the people's issues.

"This is politicisation of the issue. This is an emotional issue for the Congress but the Home Minister is looking to derive political benefit and use this to divert attention from his failures from real issues of the people," Mr. Ramesh said.

Ganga treaty not in Bihar's interests, says JD(U) leader

Nistula Hebbar
Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Janata Dal (United) national working president Sanjay Jha, who was Bihar's Minister for Water Resources between 2021 and 2024, has advocated against the renewal of the 1996 India-Bangladesh Ganga Water Treaty, saying it would hurt the interests of Bihar.

The two sides are yet to hold the last round of talks on the renewal of the treaty that will expire on December 31.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Mr. Jha said, "If you look at the data in the last 30 years of the treaty being in place, you can clearly see that the interests of Bihar have been negatively impacted."

"If you have diplomatic issues to sort out between the two countries, my only point is that Bihar's interests, too, must be kept in mind," he said, adding that the treaty may have checked a few boxes with regard to messaging in the international sphere, but had hurt the State's interests.

J&K Census enumerators raise tech concerns

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The issue of Census enumerators and supervisors having mobile devices below the required configuration in snow-bound areas of Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) was discussed at a meeting chaired by Chief Principal Census Officer (CPCO) Amit Sharma in Doda on Thursday.

Census 2027 is the country's first-ever digital Census exercise, and enumerators, mostly school

teachers and government employees, are required to capture the data through apps on their personal phones.

Officials informed the meeting about the "technical challenges" faced by field functionaries. It was explained that the mobile devices to be used for the upcoming Population Enumeration exercise are required to have a minimum of 8 GB of RAM and Android 13 or above.

"The issue of enumerators and supervisors hav-

ing devices below the required configuration was discussed for appropriate resolution," a statement from the CPCO said.

The meeting, held at the Deputy Commissioner's Office Complex, reviewed Doda district's readiness for the Population Enumeration phase scheduled from September 1 to September 30, 2026.

The second phase of the Census in Ladakh and snow-bound areas of J&K, Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh is being conduct-

ed ahead of the rest of the country. While the self-enumeration portal for these regions will remain available from August 17 to August 31, the door-to-door enumeration will start on September 1 and conclude by September 30.

Mr. Sharma stressed the need for accurate and reliable data collection, directing enumerators and supervisors to ensure that all entries are properly recorded, verified and cross-checked.

The CPCO also asked

district authorities to intensify awareness campaigns through newspapers, pamphlets, social media and local outreach programmes ahead of the enumeration exercise.

Special attention was also given to the enumeration of migratory populations, tribal communities and residents of remote forest areas.

Mr. Sharma instructed charge officers and supervisors to conduct regular field inspections and quality checks.

Congress seeks to postpone Census exercise in Manipur

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Thursday sought the postponement of the Census exercise in Manipur, citing continuing violence and the displacement of thousands of people.

Inner Manipur MP A. Bimol Akoijam of the Congress said conducting the exercise under the present circumstances would be an

injustice to those affected by the conflict.

Addressing a press conference in Delhi, Mr. Akoijam said that nearly 60,000 people remained homeless since the violence in the State began on May 3, 2023, with many still living in relief camps. Over 10,000 houses had been destroyed, he said.

The Congress clarified that it was seeking a postponement, not cancella-

tion, of the Census exercise in the State until conditions became conducive.

"Accurate house listing of thousands of homeless people living in relief camps is practically impossible. To conduct the Census in these circumstances would be to compound the injustice suffered by the people of Manipur," Mr. Akoijam said, adding that he had raised the matter in Parliament.

Papa smiling, looking down proudly, says Rahul ahead of Sonia Gandhi's memoir release

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

On his father Rajiv Gandhi's birth anniversary, senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday recalled the loss of his father and paid an emotional tribute to his mother Sonia Gandhi, saying he could imagine "Papa smiling and looking down proudly at his beautiful Sonia".

Mr. Gandhi was referring to the upcoming memoir of his mother and Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi.

In a message on X, Mr. Gandhi said he had last seen his parents together more than 35 years ago and since then watched his mother "face everything life threw at you with never-ending courage and dignity".

Only he and his sister, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, he said, knew "what you have been through, and how difficult your life after Papa truly was".

Mr. Gandhi said he was proud that Sonia Gandhi's memoir, *Belonging: A Journey of Love*, would be read by "millions of people who love you", adding that he knew how difficult it had been for someone as private as her to tell her story.

The memoir, due to be released in November, recounts her journey from Italy to India, her marriage to Rajiv Gandhi, the deaths of Indira Gandhi and Sanjay Gandhi, her entry into politics after her husband's assassination and her decision to



Congress leader Sonia Gandhi pays tributes to Rajiv Gandhi on his 82nd birth anniversary, at Vir Bhumi in New Delhi, on Thursday. PTI

decline the Prime Minister's post in 2004.

Students to drive change

At an event later in the day, Mr. Gandhi shifted from the personal to the political, saying the growing assertion by students across the country could no longer be suppressed.

"The students are saying we have an expression and we believe in certain things as individuals. I am very proud now that millions of young students have understood this," he said, adding that the "expression has suddenly come out and it cannot be stopped".

The challenge, he said, was to convert this awakening into a structural change, particularly in education.

Invoking Mahatma Gandhi's idea of *swaraj*, Mr. Gandhi said it was not merely "freedom" but "rule over oneself" and required an environment in which people could pursue their own conception of truth.

He questioned how *swaraj* could exist alongside an ex-

pensive education system, an unfair examination system, and an economy dominated by a handful of people. "How will that expression transform the education system of our country," he asked.

Mr. Gandhi also sharpened his attack on Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the BJP-RSS, saying the political contest was fundamentally about who had the right to determine what constituted truth.

"When Mr. Narendra Modi says, 'I forgive the students', meaning, 'I know everything and you don't know anything and I forgive you', that's why they attack students every single day," he said.

He accused the BJP-RSS of marginalising minorities, taking away tribal land and perpetuating caste oppression, and said the political struggle was to ensure that every citizen felt they "belong" in India. "The country should help you walk on that path. That is Gandhiji's vision for India, and that is the path of *swaraj*," he said.

Rahul seeks report on whether leaders adhere to party line

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi's grouse with colleagues for not taking up social justice issues strongly enough was reflected at the Congress Working Committee (CWC) meeting on Wednesday.

When party president Mallikarjun Kharge expressed his anguish that not many colleagues had publicly raised the issue of the "purification ritual" conducted at Uttarakhand's Haldwani, where the Congress chief had addressed a public meeting, Mr. Gandhi asked the party's social media head, Supriya Shrinat, to prepare regular reports on how many leaders were or were not amplifying the party's official line on issues.

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal did tell the Congress chief that the party had strongly condemned the incident, but he didn't seem "fully convinced," claimed party sources.

Mr. Kharge had said that there were three or four "good-looking [people] who appear on TV for their articulation", but they don't stick to the party line on crucial issues.

The closed-door meeting also witnessed a difference of opinion between senior leader Manish Te-

Kharge lamented that not many colleagues raised the issue of Haldwani 'purification ritual'

wari and Mr. Gandhi over the issue of recent students' protests.

Mr. Tewari said that there had only been a few "organic protests" and cited anti-Hindi protests in Tamil Nadu in the 1960s, students' resistance in north India against the use of the English language, the Navnirman agitation in Gujarat in the mid-1970s and the Mandal agitation in the late 1980s as examples.

He also made the point that student wings of political parties were not very successful in leading these protests.

Mr. Gandhi, however, countered this and claimed that students were with the Congress in the late 1970s and early 1980s.

Sources claimed this was the third instance when Mr. Gandhi countered Mr. Tewari at a CWC meeting. In a cryptic post following the meeting, Mr. Tewari, quoting former British Prime Minister Winston Churchill, said, "The Dictator, in all his pride, is held in the grip of his Party machine. He can go forward; he cannot go back.... All-strong without, he is all-weak within".

TIRUCHIRAPPALLI DISTRICT CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' UNION LTD.,
PUDUKKOTTAI ROAD, KOTTAPATTU, TIRUCHIRAPPALLI - 620 023. E-mail : gmaavintrichy@gmail.com
Ref. No. 04/1333/MKG/2026-28 E-TENDER NOTICE Date : 18.08.2026.
Trichy District Co-operative Milk Producers' Union Ltd invite two part sealed: tender from eligible contractors to engage hired vehicles for Milk & Milk Products Distribution and Taxi in Trichy District in Tiruchirappalli Union for the period of (2026-2028) 2 years.

Name of the Work	Vehicle Capacity (Tonnage)	No. of Vehicles	EMD (in Rs.)	Tender Number
Milk Distribution Vehicles	1.0 Ton and above	1	15,000	04/1333/MKG/2026-2028
	2.5 Ton and above	38	15,000	
By-products & Ice Cream Vehicles	1.0 Ton and above	1	15,000	
	0.7 Ton and above	1	15,000	
T-Board Taxi	(Taxi 4*1)	1	15,000	

The Tender forms can be downloaded from www.tntenders.gov.in on free of cost from the date of issue of tender notice download from 27.08.2026 onwards. The Pre-Bid meeting will be held on 02.09.2026 at 11.00 AM in Tiruchirappalli District Cooperative Milk Producers' Union Trichy. The EMD must be paid only through online www.tntenders.gov.in and duly filled tender forms should be submitted on or before 12.10.2026 by 4.00 PM through online e-procurement portal www.tntenders.gov.in only. The opening of the tender forms will be on 14.10.2026 by 11.00 AM. The General Manager has power to accept, reject or cancel the tender partially or fully.

GENERAL MANAGER,
Tiruchirappalli District Co-op. Milk Producers' Union Ltd.,
DIPR/ 2633 /TENDER/2026

**OFFICE OF THE ADDITIONAL CHIEF ENGINEER,
PHULBANI MINOR IRRIGATION CIRCLE, PHULBANI**
e-mail: mircirclephulbani@gmail.com
Letter No. **944**, Dt. **18/08/2026**

Cancellation of a bid Under e-Procurement Letter No.482/WE Dt 06.05.2026. for Bid Identification No. ACEPMC-01/2026-27

In continuation to e-Procurement Letter No.482/WE Dt.06.05.2026, it is hereby informed that the work "**Renovation to Kanganinalla MIP in Phulbani Block of Kandhamal District under DPIW Scheme for the year 2025-26**" included in the Bid Identification No.ACEPMC-01/2026-27 is hereby **cancelled** on administrative ground.

**Additional Chief Engineer,
Phulbani M.I.Circle, Phulbani**

32001/717/2627. OMPR-32001/32521/1/26-27/0004

**GOVERNMENT OF TAMILNADU
DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE
PUDUKKOTTAI - 622 001**
Ref. No.C4/7134/2026

e - TENDER NOTIFICATION
For and on behalf of the Government of Tamil Nadu, tenders in two cover system are invited from the manufacturers and fertilizer industries towards the supply of raw material for the production of Micronutrient mixtures at the Micronutrient Mixture Production unit, Kudumiyannalai, Pudukkottai District. Safe transportation of Micronutrient Mixtures (Polyester packets in sacks) from the Micronutrient Mixture Production Unit, Kudumiyannalai, Pudukkottai District and Safe transportation of Liquid Bio Fertilizers (HDPE bottles packed in carton box) from the 22 Bio Fertilizer Production units of Tamil Nadu for the year 2026-2027.

Sl. No.	Name of the Item	Approximate Value in Rs.	Earnest Money Deposit to be paid in Rs.
1	Supply of Micronutrient raw materials and printed polyester covers for packing	30,03,03,640	30,03,036
2	Safe transportation of Micronutrient Mixtures from the Micronutrient Mixture Production Unit.	1,00,00,000	1,00,000
3	Safe transportation of Liquid Bio Fertilizers from the 22 Bio Fertilizer Production units.	1,50,00,000	1,50,000

e-tender should be submitted for the items mentioned above along with specified EMD. The Tender Document is available in the Government Website <http://www.tntenders.gov.in>.
The time schedule for opening of the tender is as follows:

a	Bid Publishing Date	21.08.2026 at 10.30 am.
b	Document download start Date	21.08.2026 at 10.45 am.
c	Bid Submission Start Date	21.08.2026 at 11.30 am.
d	Pre Bid Meeting Date	03.09.2026 at 11.00 am.,11.30 am, 12.00 Noon
e	Bid submission closing Date	21.09.2026 at 10.30 am.
f	Bid opening Date	21.09.2026 at 11.30 am,12.00 Noon, 12.30 pm.

For further particular, please contact: Joint Director of Agriculture, Kattupuduhukkulam, Pudukkottai - 622 001. Phone: 04322 - 221666, email: jdapdk@gmail.com.

Joint Director of Agriculture,
Pudukkottai.

DIPR/ 2623 /TENDER/2026

INBRIEF



Sensex jumps 628 points, Nifty snaps 7-day losing streak

Benchmark equity indices bounced back on Thursday, with the Sensex climbing 628 points and the Nifty snapping its seven-day losing streak as easing global bond yields fueled a stock rally worldwide. The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 628.04 points, or 0.82%, to settle at 77,537.72 after four days of decline. During the day, it surged 701.43 points, or 0.91%, to 77,611.11. The 50-share NSE Nifty rose by 153.55 points, or 0.64%, to close at 24,231.85.

L&T-MHI wins up to ₹5,000 cr. order for APM at Dubai airport

Larsen & Toubro's (L&T) Transportation Infrastructure business, in consortium with Japan's Mitsubishi Heavy Industries (MHI), has secured a large order worth between ₹2,500 crore and ₹5,000 crore to design and build the Automated People Mover (APM) System for Phase 1 of Al Maktoum International Airport in Dubai. Once fully developed, Al Maktoum International Airport is expected to handle 260 million passengers and 12 MT of freight annually.

Investors dump India bonds after hawkish RBI minutes

A hawkish tone in the Reserve Bank of India's policy minutes jolted domestic bonds on Thursday, compounding pressure from rising oil prices and knocking the liquid 10-year benchmark to a two-month low. The yield on the benchmark 6.94% 2036 bond climbed 5 basis points to 6.8709%, its highest since June 15. The MPC minutes showed a path being built to eventual hikes, Tanay Dalal, economist at Axis Bank, said.

IndianOil to supply Mauritius ATF, petrol, diesel

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

State-owned IndianOil Thursday entered into an five-year agreement with Mauritius' State Trading Corporation for supplying petrol, diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF). Making the announcement on social media, Hardeep Puri, India's Petroleum Minister, wrote, "The agreement will meet Mauritius' requirements of petrol, diesel, marine gas oil and ATF – providing long-term supply certainty, greater price stability and enhanced energy security, while supporting the nation's mobility, connectivity and economic growth." Mauritius becomes the first country outside South Asia to have concluded a fuel supply agreement with an Indian public-sector oil entity.

Aditya Birla Capital enters gold loans; targets 1,000 branches

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Aditya Birla Capital on Thursday joined non-bank lending peers who are either entering or ramping up presence in the lucrative gold loan business. Unlike some entities, which have taken the acquisition route to enter the business, the Aditya Birla group's financial services arm seems to be focusing on building its gold lending business by itself and announced a target of 1,000 gold loan branches in three

DGCI okays Pulse's nano-carrier Vitamin D3 oral dispersion

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Pulse Pharmaceuticals has received approval for its nano-carrier entrapped Vitamin D3 oral dispersion from the Drugs Controller General of India (DCGI). The approval transforms advanced nano pharmaceutical research into a regulated, patient-ready product, the company said on Thursday. Founder and MD K. V. Rambabu said such an approval is probably the first in the world. It is set to pave the way for Pulse Pharmaceuticals to take the product to some of the neighbouring South Asian countries besides helping it in seeking regulatory approvals in highly regulated markets, including the U.S. The company which, he said, has been working in



It will start with opening up to 300 gold-loan branches.

markets, an official statement said. "Gold loans are seeing strong structural growth in India and our entry into this segment is a natural extension of our secured lending strategy," said Rakesh Singh, ED and CEO – NBFC, Aditya Birla Capital. It can be noted lending against gold has seen a huge surge in the recent past with a rise in precious metal prices. The overall portfolio loans against gold jewellery stood at ₹3.42 lakh crore at end June, up 69.3% year-on-year.

Derivatives trader base falls for first time in four years in FY26

Despite the moderation, retail traders continued to be the largest cohort of traders, a study by markets regulator SEBI noted

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The number of individual traders participating in the derivatives market fell 19% to 78.6 lakh in fiscal 2026 from 98.1 lakh a year earlier, according to data released by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on Thursday.

SEBI's two studies on the profitability and trading behaviour of individual derivatives traders, released on August 20, showed that both participation and aggregate losses declined in FY26. However, the average loss per trader increased, highlighting the continued risks faced by those remaining active in the market.

The decline in participation followed a series of measures introduced by SEBI to curb retail losses in derivatives. These included limiting weekly expiries to one index per exchange, raising the minimum contract value to ₹15 lakh-₹20 lakh and increasing the extreme loss margin for expiry-day trading by 2%.

However, SEBI cautioned against attributing the decline entirely to the regulatory measures.

"The decline cannot be attributed solely to the regulatory measures, as participation had already begun moderating before their

implementation," Prasad Patankar and Prabhas Kumar Rath of SEBI's Department of Economic and Policy Analysis II said in the study on profitability of derivative traders.

The proportion of traders who incurred losses also declined, albeit marginally, to 87.7% in FY26 from 90.9% in FY25. This was the lowest level recorded since FY22, when SEBI began its analysis.

Aggregate losses fell 18% year-on-year to ₹91,685 crore in FY26. Despite the decline, losses remained higher than the levels recorded between FY22 and FY24. At the individual level, however, the picture was rather grim. The average loss per loss-making trader increased to ₹1.16 lakh from ₹1.13 lakh in FY25, making it the highest average loss recorded since FY22. SEBI's second study found that incurring losses did not necessarily dis-

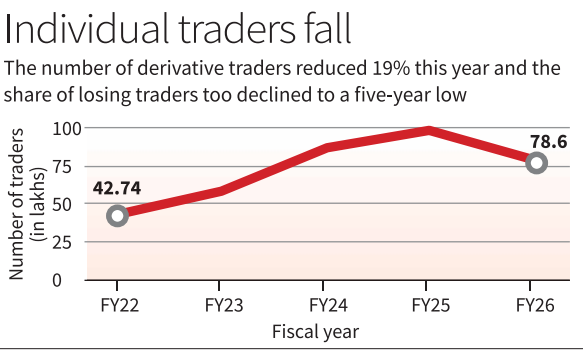
courage traders from continuing to participate in derivatives, although persistence in trading moderated during FY26.

Only about 57% of the traders who formed the FY25 cohort continued trading in FY26, compared with a long-term average of around 65%. Consequently, 43% stopped trading during the year.

SEBI found that traders who continued participating over multiple years remained highly likely to incur losses.

In FY24, as much as 91.6% of traders who had reported losses in both FY22 and FY23 also reported losses in FY24. The probability of making losses remained above 90% across traders with one to five years of experience.

Despite the decline in participation, individual traders continued to account for the largest cohort in the derivatives market.



IRDAI bars Acko General, Niva Bupa from opening new branches

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

Insurance regulator IRDAI has barred Niva Bupa Health Insurance and Acko General Insurance from opening new branches for six months after finding that both insurers exceeded the permissible Expenses of Management (EoM) limits for 2024-25.

They were "warned for failure to remain within prescribed EoM limits and directed not to open any new place of business for six months" from August 19, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India said on Thursday.

The two insurers were

IRDAI said the insurers had been warned for failing to stay within the prescribed limits

found to have exceeded the permissible EoM limits prescribed under the IRDAI (Expenses of Management, of Insurers) Regulations, 2024, following off-site monitoring, examination of their submissions and subsequent enforcement proceedings, it said.

Niva Bupa incurred actual expenses of ₹2,652.12 crore against the allowable expenses of ₹2,403.75

crore, resulting in an excess expenditure of ₹248.37 crore. For Acko General the allowable expenses were ₹650.37 crore, while it incurred actual expenses of ₹985.15 crore, resulting in ₹334.78 crore excess expenditure.

IRDAI said the insurers had been warned for failing to stay within the prescribed limits, adding that EoM include operational and distribution costs. The regulator said insurers must adhere to these limits to curb excessive operating and management expenses and ensure that a reasonable share of the premiums collected is used to provide insurance coverage and settle claims.

'MMDR Amendment Act expected to bring greater tax uniformity'

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The MMDR Amendment Act, 2026 is expected to address long-standing operational challenges in the mining sector by bringing greater uniformity and predictability to the levy regime, FICCI Mining Committee Chair and NMDC CMD Amitava Mukherjee said on Thursday.

The amendment to the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957, is aimed at curbing non-uniform state taxes and unexpected cesses that have increased the

cost of mineral extraction and created uncertainty for the industry. A more certain taxation and levy framework could encourage fresh capital investment while accelerating the exploration and development of mineral resources, he said in a statement.

Mukherjee said empowering the Centre to streamline levies on mineral-bearing lands under the newly introduced Section 9D would help create a transparent and predictable framework for mining companies operating across different States.

NSE shares may trade on its platform as 'permitted'

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The National Stock Exchange (NSE) may allow its shares to trade on its platform after being listed on a rival bourse, without requiring a separate approval from Sebi, as the proposed arrangement would fall under the exchange's existing 'permitted-to-trade' framework, an industry source said on Thursday. Under the permitted-to-trade framework, an exchange can allow trading in shares listed on another recognised stock exchange.

Return to core values to reform Tata Sons

OPINION
Arun Maira

Tata Sons is at a crossroad. What form of corporate governance should it adopt? Tata Sons is the steward of the Tata group. The Tata Sons board structure and the values which guide it must be aligned with the values with which the Tata group of companies, each of which was a pioneer in Indian industry, was created. Should the governance of Tata Sons comply with modern stock market values or with Tata values to continue the nation-building purpose for which the Tata group was founded over one hundred years ago?

Group's evolution

Tata Sons built India's largest iron and steel company with its supporting mines' system, in the face of British opposition, in 1907; the largest hydro-electric power company soon after and the largest chain of hotels and a large chemicals company. After India's independence, Tatas built India's largest automobile company with a nation-wide industry of auto parts' suppliers to support it; also, India's largest IT software company.

Along the way, Tatas helped the government of Singapore in the 1970s, to build a training school for high-skilled workers and a precision tool room to provide the foundations for Singapore's industries.

The Tata Trusts own 66.4% of Tata Sons (while several Tata companies own 12.8% and the Tata family 2.4%). Therefore, two-thirds of the dividends Tata Sons receives from the profits of the companies in which it has invested, go to the Trusts for philanthropic



At crossroad: Head office of the Tata group in Mumbai, India. REUTERS

ic purposes. Tata Trusts founded the Indian Institute of Science in 1909; the Tata Institute of Social Sciences in 1936; the Tata Memorial Hospital for cancer research in 1941 and the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research in 1945. All these institutions were established before India's independence from British rule in 1947. The Tata Trusts have continued philanthropic work after independence: they are India's largest philanthropists.

Governance structure

J.R.D. Tata was Chairman of Tata Sons from 1938 to 1991, when he handed over the reins to Ratan Tata. JRD steered the group through many difficulties for the Indian economy, pre-and post-independence and nurtured the formation of pioneering companies in many industries. All major Tata companies were listed on the stock market as soon as they were formed, so that they could bring in capital to build them. The Tata Trusts were minority shareholders. For many years, the Birlas owned more shares in Tata Steel than the Tatas; and the Ta-

tas also owned fewer shares in Tata Engineering and Locomotive Company (TELCO, which was renamed as Tata Motors later) than Daimler Benz, Tata's technology partner in the joint venture.

Managing directors of the Tata companies (as CEOs were then known) were appointed by their own shareholders and boards. Tata Sons chose leaders with the requisite domain knowledge, who also subscribed to Tata's philosophy of nation building and social responsibility, and recommended their appointment to the company's shareholders. J.R.D. Tata was chairman of the board of all major companies. Naval Tata, his cousin, was the chairman of the others. As the chairs of their boards, they oversaw their companies' strategic directions and ensured that they practiced Tata values of accountability to all stakeholders. These included the nurturing of talent of employees and their families' long-term welfare; care of the communities and the environment around their factories and honesty to their custom-

ers. Tata companies' stocks were safe investments. Investors and pensioners, who needed stable incomes along with growth of the value of their investments, valued Tata stocks.

Industry builders

J.R.D. Tata built a team of industry builders: Sumant Moolgaokar (TELCO), Darbari Seth (Tata Chemicals), F.C. Kohli (TCS), Ajit Kerkar (Indian Hotels), and Xerxes Desai (Titan). He appointed Moolgaokar as the chairman of TELCO and vice-chairman of Tata Sons. Naval Tata was the deputy chairman of Tata Sons. Ratan Tata took over Mr. Moolgaokar's positions in 1989 when Mr. Moolgaokar retired, as a step up to his role as chairman of Tata Sons in 1991 when JRD retired.

Winds of free market capitalism began sweeping into India in 1991 with the liberalisation of the economy, with more freedom for financial investors to roam across international borders. The Tata group went along with the winds of the U.S. style capitalism that spread across the world. Tatas attracted investors

from abroad and hired foreign managers, too. Along with them came U.S. concepts of corporate governance, viz:

1. The purpose of a business must be only business, and a business' purpose is to produce financial returns for its owners.

2. Equity of the societal kind must be subservient to equity for financial investors.

3. The governance role of the chairman of the board must be combined with the executive role of the CEO to enable swifter execution and avoid confusion between the social responsibility of the corporation and production of profits.

4. Conglomerates must be broken up so that investors can gauge the financial worthiness of their pieces separately.

The Tata group has held together so far; but the conflict of social values with capital valuations are now showing up in its structure. To reconcile them and enable the group to raise capital while adhering to Tata's historical values, the Tata Sons board must be reformed.

Conflict of structure

The conflict amongst Tata Sons and the Tata Trusts is not a conflict amongst personalities. Conflicts have been created by the structure of the Tata Sons' board. The roles of chairman of the board and the CEO must be separated. And both, the chairman of the board and the CEO, must be competent for their distinct roles.

(The writer is the author of *The Learning Factory: How the Leaders of Tatas Became Nation Builders and Ratan Tata - a life in innovation and enterprise, published by The Hindu*)

ANKARA
Turkiye denies military presence at Syrian airbase struck by Israel



Turkiye on Thursday denied having any military presence at an airbase in north Syria struck by Israel earlier this week, and vowed to continue “resolutely” supporting Syrian sovereignty. The denial came two days after Syria accused Israel of hitting a disused military airbase that was damaged during the civil war. AFP

GAZA CITY
Hind Rajab's family says Israel's probe attempt to 'justify' killing



The grandmother of Hind Rajab said that her family had no faith in a criminal probe into the five-year-old's death in Gaza in 2024, calling it an attempt by the Israeli military to “justify” her killing. Hind Rajab's body was recovered from a car riddled with bullets days after she was last heard in a phone call for help. AFP

GUSAU
Overloaded boat capsizes in Nigeria, 40 children's bodies found



An overloaded boat capsized in Nigeria's northwest Sokoto state, with around 40 bodies of children recovered so far, a local official at the inland waterways authority said on Thursday. The accident occurred in the morning when people were heading either to plant or to harvest rice, said Sarkin Daji, a traditional leader. REUTERS

DHAKA
'Possibility of Tarique's India visit slim without dignified invitation'



The possibility of Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's visit to India next month for BRICS Summit “remains slim” unless an appropriate environment based on “mutual trust” is created, along with a “dignified invitation” from New Delhi, his Foreign Affairs Adviser Humaiun Kobir has said. PTI

Trump pledges 'economic warfare' on Iran, prompting Tehran derision

Any country providing 'any type of lifeline to Iran' would face 'tremendous economic consequences,' warns U.S. President; Iran dismisses the move as a continuation of 'failed policies,' maintaining economic pressure by keeping Hormuz closed

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

U.S. President Donald Trump pledged “economic warfare” against Iran and threatened any country that trades with it, prompting Iran to dismiss the plan on Thursday as a continuation of failed policies.

The war between the two countries, started by the U.S. and Israel in February, appears stalemated, with peace talks stalled, Tehran keeping the key Strait of Hormuz shut and Washington persisting with a naval counter-blockade of Iran.



The U.S. Navy Nimitz-class aircraft carrier USS Abraham Lincoln conducts a replenishment-at-sea on August 16. REUTERS

In a post on his Truth Social, the U.S. leader said he was announcing “the MOST CRUSHING ECONOMIC OPERATION EVER

TAKEN AGAINST ANY COUNTRY! This will be Economic Warfare and Isolation on an unprecedented scale”.

“ANY country that allows its financial institutions, businesses, airports, or government entities to provide any type of lifeline to Iran will itself face TREMENDOUS Economic Consequences,” he said. The U.S. has maintained punishing sanctions against Iran for decades, with Mr. Trump in his 2017-2021 first term ratcheting them up as part of a “maximum pressure” strategy in which he tore up a nuclear deal negotiated by his predecessor Barack Obama. Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Thursday dismissed the plan as a continuation of “failed pol-

icies”, which he said would bring Washington “further defeat”. “The so-called ‘Economic D-Day’ is a diversion from America’s own crisis: unprecedented debt & surging interest costs. Doubling down on failed policies will only bring further defeat – and enmity of Iranians,” Mr. Araghchi said in a post on X. “U.S. economic terrorism threatens global economy and sovereignty worldwide.” Tehran, though, continues to exert its own economic pressure campaign by keeping the Strait of Hormuz largely closed.

BNP's Alamgir elected new President of Bangladesh

Press Trust of India
DHAKA

Mirza Fakhru Islam Alamgir, a long-time secretary general of the ruling Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) and a close ally of former premier Khaleda Zia, was on Thursday elected as the country's new President in the first contested poll for the post in 35 years. The 78-year-old BNP stalwart defeated his lone rival Colonel (ret'd) Oli Ahmed, the 84-year-old Liberal Democratic Party chairman and the nominee of the Jamaat-e-Islami-led 11-party Opposition alliance, Chief Election Commissioner and also Election Returning Officer AMM Nasir Uddin announced after the counting



Mirza Fakhru Islam Alamgir

presidential election in Bangladesh since 1991, as the office had largely been filled through consensus and uncontested polls in recent decades. Prime Minister Tarique Rahman congratulated Mr. Alamgir on his victory in the presidential polls. Law-makers also congratulated the President-elect by thumping their desks. The presidential election was necessitated after Mohammed Shahabuddin, a close aide of deposed Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, resigned last month on health grounds before completing his five-year tenure. Under the Constitution, a new President is required to be elected within 90 days of the office falling vacant.

Russian strikes kill 16 in Ukraine; Zelenskyy flags missile shortage

Reuters
KYIV

A major Russian air strike killed 16 people and injured more than 40 in Kyiv and the surrounding region on Thursday as President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said a failure by Ukraine's allies to replenish its stock of air defence missiles was costing lives.

Ukraine's air force said Russia launched dozens of cruise missiles, as well as ballistic and hypersonic ones, and 168 drones, in the massive overnight attack.

The air force said that nearly 90% of the drones and most of the cruise missiles were downed. Mr. Zelenskyy called



Volodymyr Zelenskyy

Thursday's strike one of the most “cynical, calculated, and large-scale” of the four-and-a-half-year-long war. The Russian Defence Ministry said Moscow attacked Kyiv and the surrounding region, hitting facilities producing drone components, a military depot and a logistics hub.

Romania destroys marine drone near offshore gas project

Agence France-Presse
BUCHAREST

A Romanian F-16 fighter jet on Thursday destroyed a marine drone near an offshore gas project, with Romania's President blaming Russia for the latest incident involving the NATO member bordering Ukraine.

Unauthorised drone activity has become increasingly frequent in recent months across eastern European countries as Ukraine fights off a Russian invasion launched in 2022, with both countries increasingly relying on drone warfare. In the latest incident, the drone that was destroyed was “loaded with

explosives” and did not originate from Ukraine, Defence Minister Radu Miruta said on Facebook. “I strongly condemn the escalation of such irresponsible incidents on the part of the Russian Federation,” Romanian President Nicusor Dan said on X. European Commission chief Ursula von der Leyen also slammed “an escalating campaign of threats” against the bloc, “unsettling our citizens and seeking to divide our Union”. “This is hybrid warfare,” she wrote on X. The drone was spotted hundreds of metres from the offshore gas project Neptun Deep and 80 nautical miles east of the Black Sea city of Constanta.

China jails Evergrande founder for life, imposes fine of over \$2 billion on firm

Agence France-Presse
BEIJING

China on Thursday sentenced the founder of embattled property giant Evergrande to life in prison and fined the company and an affiliate more than \$2 billion after a high-profile default five years ago. Evergrande Group was the face of Chinese real estate, surfing a decades-long property boom as it peddled home-ownership dreams but its access to credit dramatically narrowed when the government introduced curbs on excessive borrowing and speculation. The company defaulted in 2021 after struggling to repay creditors.



Life sentence: Evergrande founder Xu Jiayin during a trial in Shenzhen, southern China's Guangdong province. AFP

On Thursday, a court in south China fined the firm and its real estate arm a total of 15.82 billion yuan (\$2.4 billion). It sentenced founder Xu Jiayin, known as Hui Ka Yan in Cantonese, to life for a list of crimes includ-

ing “large-scale financial fraud”. “Xu Jiayin was sentenced for multiple crimes and fined, received a life sentence, with political rights revoked for life and all his personal property confiscated,” the Shenzhen

Intermediate People's Court in Guangdong province said in a post on its WeChat account. Between 2016 and 2021, Evergrande and Mr. Xu as boss “violated national laws by engaging in continuous, large-scale financial fraud and other means to inflate assets and conceal liabilities”, the court said. It added that the parties “gained control of financial institutions” through bribery. Mr. Xu pleaded guilty in April to charges that also included embezzlement and bribery. Five other senior executives of Evergrande Group were also sentenced to prison terms ranging up to 18 years for crimes including fraud.

TIRUMALA TIRUPATI DEVASTHANAMS, TIRUPATI
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, T.T.D., TIRUPATI
TENDER NOTICE
Adv. No.27/03/CE/TTD/2026-27, NIT No.73/SEC/ & NIT No.339/SE-4/TTD/2026-27, Dated: 20-08-2026
Name of Work : 1) Construction of Additional floor to the existing building (i.e., 3rd Floor) North and East side wing at S.V.High school, TTD, Tirupati Amount Rs. 547.60 Lakhs, Time for Completion : 18 Months.
(2) Supply, Installation, Testing, Commissioning of an Internet Things (IoT) based Real Time Monitoring system for Quality and Quantity of Water supplied at Tirumala including Operation and Maintenance (O&M) for two years, Open Tender type, Time for completion : 6 months (Installation) + 24 months (O&M). Note For full details, log onto the website <http://www.tirumala.org>.
TTD-40021(31)/1/2026-PRO SEC(Adv.No.158), Date: 20.08.2026 EXECUTIVE OFFICER

TIRUMALA TIRUPATI DEVASTHANAMS, TIRUPATI
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ACCOUNTS OFFICER, T.T.D., TIRUPATI
RFP NOTIFICATION
File Roc. No.A13/TTD-53023(31)/68/2026-A Wing Sec-TTD
"Sealed RFPs are invited for undertaking the Management Audit i.e. independent examination and certification of the Financial Statements of Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams for the Financial Year 2025-26 from the category 1 CA Firms. The sealed RFPs should reach us on or before 15 days from the date of advertisement of notification. For other details please visit TTD Website: <http://www.tirumala.org>"
TTD-40021(31)/1/2026-PRO SEC(Adv.No.159), Date: 20.08.2026 EXECUTIVE OFFICER

JAIPUR CITY TRANSPORT SERVICES LIMITED
No.- MD/JCTSL/2026-27/0-1573 Date = 17/08/2026
NOTICE INVITING BIDS
NIB No. 02/2026-27 Date 17-08-2026
Bid for Procurement of Selection of Bus Operator for Procurement, Supply, Operation and Maintenance of 50 Fully Built Pure Electric Double Decker AC Buses and Development of Allied Electrical and Civil Infrastructure on Gross Cost Contracting (GCC) on Hop- on Hop off Basis in Jaipur, Jodhpur and Udaipur Cities" are invited from interested bidder upto 22-09-2026 time at 18:00 hrs. Participants of the bid may visit on procurement portal <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> or e-procurement Portal, <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> or the official website of JCTSL <http://transport.rajasthan.gov.in/jctsl>. UBN No. JCT2627SLOB00002
Managing Director JCTSL, Jaipur
Raj.Samwadi/C/26/10360

THE NATIONAL SMALL INDUSTRIES CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)
Corporate Identification No. U74140DL1955GOI002481
RFPs for Selection of Vendors for Supply of Toolkits for 02 Trades under PM Vishwakarma Scheme
NSIC invites online Bids on GeM portal against RFPs stated in the title above on behalf of Ministry of MSME.
The details of the RFPs are available under the web-links <https://gem.gov.in/> and <https://www.nsic.co.in/Tenders/Index> and may be downloaded.
Last date for submission of proposal-07.09.2026
Any further announcement/corrigendum regarding above RFPs will be made available on above two web-links.

PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT
Office of the Executive Engineer, No.1, Building Division, SJP Campus, Bengaluru, Phone: 080-22255210
No. EE/Bid-1/AE-284/2026-27/19 Date: 17.08.2026
INVITATION FOR TENDER (IFT)
The above Department invites Tenders through e-procurement portal of GoK (<http://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>) from eligible Tenderers for Proposed construction of Karnataka Bhavan-4 Plot No.-5, Annual Maintenance of sanitary, water supply and carpentry, providing renovation and improvements works to Krishna Cell in Karnataka Bhavan-3 (Bheema) and other development works, total of 03 works at various notified places. Approx. value of work: Min. Rs. 20.17 lakhs, Max. Rs. 4410.56 lakhs. EMD: Min. Rs. 25,000/-, Max. Rs. 44,10,600/-. Time Period: 3 to 18 Months (including rainy season). Cost of Document for each work: As in e-portal. Last date for downloading Tender through e-procurement portal and submission through online: For SI. No. 1: 01.09.2026, For SI. No. 2 & 3: 25.08.2026 up to 4.30 PM. Date of opening the Tender: as per e-procurement guidelines. Further information, brief details of the works, Indent No.s, approx. amount, EMD and mode of payment, Reservation, etc. can be obtained from the above office or from e-procurement portal <http://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>
Sd/- Executive Engineer
DIPR/DD-C. P/2343/KSMCA/2026-27

KERALA STATE ELECTRICITY BOARD LIMITED - TENDER NOTICE
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER (COMMERCIAL & TARIFF), Vidyuthi Bhavanam, Thiruvananthapuram
Inviting Short term tender for the procurement of Power from 01.10.2026 to 15.05.2027 on firm and short term basis from any Sources, through e-bidding portal (DEEP) only.
DEEP Portal Reference No - KSEB/Short/26-27/ET/50 Dtd 20.08.2026.
Last Date for submission of queries - 22.08.2026
Submission of RFP (on line digitally signed non financial technical Bid and IPOs) - 31.08.2026, 02.00 pm. For more details visit www.kseb.in
Ref: PR/MC/1/F-397/2026

The National University of Advanced Legal Studies, (NUALS), Kochi.
(Established by Act 27 of 2005 of the Kerala Legislature)
Kalamassery, Kochi, Kerala, Pin-683 503
Applications are invited from eligible candidates, for the following regular posts:
Professor in Law - One Post (Reserved for E/B/T)
Assistant Professor in Law - One post (Reserved for SC)
Last date for receipt of applications is 03.09.2026
For further details and application format, visit 'www.nuals.ac.in'
Ph No.9446899006.
Sd/- Registrar

KAMARAJAR PORT LIMITED
(A Company of Chennai Port Authority)
No.47, Rajaji Salai, Chennai - 600 001
CIN: U45203TN1999PLC043322
NOTICE INVITING GLOBAL e-TENDER
TENDER No: KPL/PPD/CT-2/PPP/2026
Kamarajar Port invites online tender in a single stage, two-cover system (RFQ cum RFP) from reputed firms for "Development of Second Container Terminal at Kamarajar Port Limited under PPP Mode on Design, Build, Finance, Operate and Transfer (DBFOT) Basis" for a Concession period of 40 (forty) years at an estimated value of **4288.26 Crore**.
The bid documents can be downloaded from Central Public Procurement (CPP) portal (www.eprocure.gov.in) from 20.08.2026.
General Manager (CS&BD)

इंटरनेशनल एडवांस्ड रिसर्च सेंटर फॉर पाउडर मेटलर्जी एंड न्यू मटेरियल्स (इंआरसीआई), हैदराबाद
(विज्ञान एवं प्रौद्योगिकी विभाग, भारत सरकार का स्वायत्त अनुसंधान एवं विकास केन्द्र)
आरसीआई, न्यू एअरपोर्ट रोड, बालापुर, हैदराबाद - 500 005, तेलंगाना
INTERNATIONAL ADVANCED RESEARCH CENTRE FOR POWDER METALLURGY AND NEW MATERIALS (ARCI)
(An Autonomous R&D Centre of Department of Science & Technology, Govt. of India)
RCI-New Airport Road, Balapur, Hyderabad-500 005, Telangana.
Ph. Nos. 040-24452515/425/356, Email : rectt@arci.res.in
विज्ञान पर संस्था/Advt. No.: ARCI/HRD/Projects/2/2026
अनुबंध पर परियोजना वैज्ञानिकों & सिविल इंजीनियर की नियुक्ति
Engagement of Project Scientists & Civil Engineer on Contract
एआरसीआई, हैदराबाद समग्र बजट प्रायोजित परियोजनाओं के लिए अनुबंध आधार पर निम्नलिखित परियोजना वैज्ञानिकों & सिविल इंजीनियर नियोजित करना चाहता है:
ARCI, Hyderabad is looking to engage following Project Scientists & Civil Engineer on Contract Basis for Time-Bound Sponsored Projects:

पदों का ब्यौरा/Details of Posts	
1. परियोजना वैज्ञानिक-1 (2 पद) Project Scientist-1 (2 posts) निश्चित परिलब्धियां/ Fixed Emoluments: (i) Rs. 77,000/- + HRA - 1 post (ii) Rs. 65,000/- (all inclusive) - 1 post	2. सिविल इंजीनियर - (1 पद) Civil Engineer - (1 post) निश्चित परिलब्धियां/ Fixed Emoluments: Rs. 1,00,000/- (all inclusive)

ऑनलाइन आवेदन प्रस्तुत करने की अंतिम तिथि 10.09.2026 है।
Last Date for Submission of Online Applications is 10.09.2026.
पूरी जानकारी के लिए लॉग ऑन करें/For complete details, log on to:
<https://www.arci.res.in/careers/vacancies>

Alcaraz recovers from wrist injury, set to play at the US Open



Lanka adds Mishara, Arachchige to squad for second Test against India



I should've been patient overall: Sindhu after losing at the Worlds



Not a revolution, but an evolution of the scoring system: Lund



India survives England's onslaught, advances

After glory in Galle, it's time for Team India to iron out the flaws

England pulls ahead in the Leeds Test

A Ukrainian partnership forged by displacement

NEW DELHI

The connection to Ukraine brings pride and pressure. They want to show that they are “strong enough” to represent their country at a “high level and make it proud”. That responsibility has become more complicated as the sporting world debates Russia's return. Yevheniia called it “a bad idea to allow them to play because it's not fair”, stressing that she holds nothing against the Russian athletes.

INBRIEF



Lee, Baena guide Atletico to opening Liga win over Malaga

Kang-In Lee and Alex Baena's, *in pic*, superb strikes helped Atletico Madrid kick off its LaLiga campaign with a 2-0 win over Malaga on Wednesday.

The result: Atletico Madrid 2 (Lee 70, Baena 85) bt Malaga 0.

India U-20 men play out goalless draw with Yemen

The India U-20 men's team were held to a 0-0 draw by Yemen in the first of two closed-door friendly matches in Bengaluru on Thursday. India will meet Yemen again on Sunday. The Blue Colts are preparing for the AFC U-20 Asian Cup China 2027 Qualifiers, which will be held in Uzbekistan from August 31 to September 6. They will depart for Tashkent on August 26.

Haryana, Jharkhand, MP and Chhattisgarh in semifinals

Haryana defeated Chandigarh 3-1 in the quarterfinals of the 16th Hockey India-National junior women hockey championship in Pune on Thursday.

The results (quarterfinals): Jharkhand 1 (Rajni Kerketta 33) drew with Odisha 1 (Lugun Anjulata 33). *Jharkhand won 4-3 in shoot-out*; Madhya Pradesh 3 (Kajal 25 & 43, Tanvi 9) bt Manipur 1 (Chanu Romita Waribam 44); Haryana 3 (Durga 14, Diksha 19, Kaur Sukhpreet 59) bt Chandigarh 1 (Apram 39); Chhattisgarh 5 (Yashoda 9 & 37 Rukhamani 19, Anjali Ekka 24, Yadav Sheetal 44) bt Uttar Pradesh 2 (Sonkar Payal 22, Annu 33).

Hyderabad races scheduled for August 24 cancelled

The stewards of the Hyderabad Race Club have resolved to cancel the races scheduled for August 24 (Monday) due to paucity of runners.

Tanishka and Prateek clinch under-15 titles

Tanishka Kalbhairav of Karnataka and Maharashtra's Prateek Tulsani began the new season on a winning note, claiming the under-15 girls' and boys' titles respectively at the UTT National Ranking Table Tennis tournament in Kanpur on Thursday.

The results: U-15: Boys: Final: Prateek Tulsani (Mah) bt Rajdeep Biswas (WB) 11-6, 11-9, 11-9; **semifinals:** Prateek bt Rishaan Chattopadhyay (WB) 13-11, 11-8, 11-6; Rajdeep bt Trijal Vohra (Pun) 14-12, 13-11, 7-11, 6-11, 13-11. **Girls: Final:** Tanishka Kalbhairav (Kar) bt Satorya Banerjee (WB) 9-11, 13-11, 7-11, 11-6, 11-6; **semifinals:** Tanishka bt Shariqa Shahid (WB) 11-5, 11-9, 13-11; Satorya bt B. Varnica (TN) 13-11, 7-11, 12-10, 11-8.

Heptathlete Swapna Barman provisionally suspended

Former Asian Games gold medallist heptathlete Swapna Barman has been provisionally suspended for testing positive for a banned substance. Swapna has returned a positive result for endogenous steroid boldenone, according to information published by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA). Swapna announced her retirement from athletics on July 31. Meanwhile, a NADA Disciplinary Panel has suspended former Asian silver medallist javelin thrower Shivpal Singh for 10 years for a second doping offence, testing positive for methandienone. Sprinter M.V. Jilna has been provisionally suspended for her second offence. Middle distance runner Sanjana Singh has been handed a five-year suspension, from Nov. 7, 2025

LIVE TELECAST

Badminton: World Championships, Sports 18-1, 3, JioHotstar & BWF Official YouTube channel, 10.30 a.m.
Hockey World Cup: Women, SS Select 2, Star Sports First & JioHotstar, 1 p.m. 4, 6.30 & 9.30 p.m.; **Men:** SS Select 2, Star Sports First & JioHotstar, 2.30 p.m. 5.30, 8.30 p.m. & 12 a.m. (Saturday).
England vs Pakistan: First Test, Day 3, Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 3.30 p.m.
TNPL: Sony Sports Ten 4 Tamil & TNPL Official YouTube channel (youtube@tamilnadupremierleague.com) 3.30 & 7.30 p.m.
Formula One: Dutch GP (Sprint shootout), F1 TV, F1 TV Pro App & FanCode, 8 p.m.
Premier League: SS Select 1 & JioHotstar, 12.30 a.m. (Saturday).
LaLiga: FanCode, 12.30 a.m. (Saturday).
Australia vs Bangladesh: Second Test, Day 1, Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 5.30 a.m. (Saturday).

FOOTBALL

Sankar Narayanan E.H.

Football moves on fast. The Premier League no longer has the enigmatic Pep Guardiola, nor does it have the prolific Mohamed Salah.

"A new era begins" is the operative phrase ahead of the 2026-27 season as five of the 'Big Six' clubs come in with a different manager compared to day one of the previous campaign.

Nineteen of 20 head coaches at the helm this season are yet to win the toughest league in the world — a fact that lends weight to Mikel Arteta and Arsenal's cause.

Counterbalancing the Gunners' case is a daunting statistic: only three clubs have ever managed to retain the trophy in the



A man apart: Arsenal's Arteta is the only one among the 20 managers this season who has the ultimate trophy under his belt. GETTY IMAGES

Premier League era.

While Bruno Guimaraes adds depth and vision to Arsenal's midfield, Arteta will have to be wary of the

fitness of William Saliba (expected to miss a couple of months), Bukayo Saka, and Declan Rice, all coming off a gruelling World

Cup campaign.

Manchester City has not only lost Guardiola, after a 10-year reign with 20 trophies, but also midfield

Praggnanandhaa finishes second in Sinquefield Cup

CHESS

Press Trust of India
ST LOUIS (USA)

Indian Grandmaster R. Praggnanandhaa tied with Wesley So for the top spot on points after nine rounds but lost out in the Armageddon to finish second in the Sinquefield Cup here.

After drawing with Anish Giri of the Netherlands in the final round, Praggnanandhaa forced a tiebreaker against So, who was leading for the most part. In the tie-break, So played out a draw with black pieces in the Armageddon to win the tournament after the two Rapid games were drawn.

Praggnanandhaa needed to beat Giri to edge past So in the standings but the Dutchman found some re-



So. FLICKR/GRANDCHESTOUR

sourceful moves when it mattered the most.

In the final round, Uzbekistan's Javokhir Sindarov had to win with black against So to catch up with him at the top. The American played solidly, exchanged pieces at will and reached a bishop and pawns endgame to force a draw.

In the Cairns Cup for women, China's Tan Zhongyi emerged champion despite going down in the final round to Stavroula Tsolakidou of Greece.

The results (ninth round): Sinquefield Cup: Wesley So (USA) 5.5 drew with Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb) 5; Jordan van Foreest (Ned) 2 drew with Vincent Keymer (Ger) 5; Levon Aronian (USA) 4 drew with Samuel Sevian (USA) 4.5; Fabiano Caruana (USA) 4.5 drew with Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (Fra) 4.5; R. Praggnanandhaa 5.5 drew with Anish Giri (Ned) 4.

Tiebreak: So beat Praggnanandhaa 1-1, 1-0.

Cairns Cup: Stavroula Tsolakidou (Gre) 4.5 bt Tan Zhongyi (Chn) 6.5; Alice Lee (USA) 6 drew with Carissa Yip (USA) 5; Bibisara Assaubayeva (Kaz) 5 drew with Koneru Humpy 3.5; Divya Deshmukh 4.5 drew with Anna Muzychuk (Ukr) 4.5; Alexandra Kosteniuk (Rus) 3 bt R. Vaishali 2.5.

Venue change shows that cricket needs fans and fans need cricket

DULEEP TROPHY

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

On Duleep Trophy match-days at the BCCI Centre of Excellence (CoE) on the outskirts of Bengaluru last year, there was a familiar sight.

A small group of enthusiastic fans would gather near the gates, hoping to watch some of the country's finest domestic cricketers in action.

But more often than not, they were left disappointed.

Security personnel would bluntly tell them that spectators were not allowed inside.

The fans would linger for a while and try their luck but would reluctantly walk away eventually.

On one occasion, a per-

The decision to move the final to Chennai is an acknowledgement that domestic cricket needs an audience

son claiming to be a player's relative had to make several phone calls and wait for hours before finally being permitted entry.

It was an odd situation for a tournament of the Duleep Trophy's stature.

This is not an isolated instance. When Karnataka hosted Kerala in a Ranji Trophy match at the Alur grounds here, spectators eager to catch a glimpse of Sanju Samson were not allowed.

That is why the BCCI's decision to move this season's Duleep Trophy final from the CoE to Chennai's M.A. Chidambaram Stadi-

um, specifically to accommodate fans, is more than just a change of venue.

It is a welcome acknowledgement that domestic cricket needs an audience. When BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia was asked why spectators could not attend the matches, he said that the Board would consider moving the final. Around 10 days later, it did just that.

Crowd presence does more than enliven the stands. A cheer can provide an emotional lift to players in the often unsung setting of First Class cricket.

The Duleep Trophy may not have the glamour of the IPL or international cricket, but for generations of players, it has been a significant stepping stone to the National team.

The fans deserve to be a part of the journey.

East Bengal women score 12 past Rovers

Press Trust of India
KOTA KINABALU (MALAYSIA)

East Bengal FC secured its second consecutive victory after romping to a 12-0 win over Rovers FC (Guam) in the AFC Women's Champions League 2026-27 preliminary stage here on Thursday.

The Moshal Girls created history by recording the biggest-ever victory by an Indian club in an Asian competition, overtaking the 9-0 win by East Bengal's men's team against Club Valencia (Maldives) in the 1985-86 Asian Club Championship.

Nine different East Bengal players found the net, underlining the depth of Anthony Andrews' side as it continued its strong start to the continental campaign.

The win puts East Bengal one win away from the group stage, with Malaysia's Sabah FA its opponent on Sunday.

The result: Rovers FC 0 lost to East Bengal FC 12 (Priyangka 6 & 22, Oraon 15, Anokye 48 & 58, Antwi 49, Sulanjana 51, Hemam 56, Opoku 64 & 70, Kayenpaibam 73, Guguloth 90+3).

Nishika, Tanisha star for Superstarz

DPL

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

The opening game of the women's section of the Delhi Premier League saw South Delhi Superstarz defeat Central Delhi Queens by 29 runs at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Thursday.

Batting first, Superstarz rode on half-centuries by Nishika Singh and Tanisha Singh to post a total of 156 for five in 20 overs. In response, Queens could only manage to score 127 for seven.

Nishika and Tanisha played pivotal roles for the victorious outfit. Having come together at 33 for two in the sixth over, the duo stitched together a partnership of 82 runs off 61 deliveries for the third wicket. The alliance broke when Nishika was dismissed on 50 by Medhavi Bidhuri in the 16th over. Tanisha fell in the 18th over after contributing a 42-ball 64 that included 10 fours.

While Nidhi Mahto struck 63 in the chase, the fact that she consumed 55



Tanisha's 64 was studded with 10 fours.

deliveries left Queens with too much to do in the latter stages. For Superstarz, Roopali Mohan, Mayuri Singh and Disha Nagar picked two scalps each.

The scores: South Delhi Superstarz 156/5 in 20 overs (Nishika Singh 50, Tanisha Singh 64, Sumiti Soni 2/13, Medhavi Bidhuri 2/24) bt Central Delhi Queens 127/7 in 20 overs (Nidhi Mahto 63, Monika 30, Roopali Mohan 2/25, Mayuri Singh 2/15, Disha Nagar 2/25).

The Pant paradox

He has enthralled and enchanted with his unchecked pyrotechnics steeped in immense self-belief and great faith in his abilities; for some strange reason known only to those, a section of critics has taken it upon itself to dissect his every move and irrevocably affix the tag ‘irresponsible’ against his name

R. Kaushik
COLOMBO

Rishabh Pant isn’t a blink-and-you-miss-it circus act, but you simply can’t take your eyes off him when he is on the cricket ground. Behind the stumps, he is a veritable motormouth, interspersing advice and tips to bowlers with hilarious one-liners bereft of foul language and malice. His sense of humour is earthy and relatable, and often elicits guffaws from opposition batters at whom smart comments are directed. He has quick hands, not quite as quicksilver as his hero and role model Mahendra Singh Dhoni but exceptionally rapid in their own right, and he has managed to strike a balance between the Dhoni school of wicketkeeping and his own brand, also steeped in unorthodoxy like the legendary Jharkhandi.

But it’s in front of the sticks that Pant is at his most entertaining. Or frustrating. Exhilarating. Or exasperating. Or all these at the same time. He can make the most outlandish look ridiculously pedestrian, but he can also infuriate with an apparent disregard, if not disrespect, for game situations when he bats seemingly without a care in the world.

Extraordinary efforts

Pant has produced some of the most extraordinary efforts in Test cricket by an Indian in recent times. In Sydney and Cape Town and Leeds and Birmingham, as much as in Chennai on his comeback to Test cricket after his horrendous road accident in December 2022, he has enthralled and enchanted with his unchecked pyrotechnics steeped in immense self-belief and great faith in his abilities. Equally, like in Melbourne 2024 or even in Galle last week, he has almost infuriated with a carefreeness bordering on the careless.

But it’s all of these that contribute to the package that the little dynamite answering to the name of Rishabh Pant is. For some strange reason known only to those, a section of critics has taken it upon itself to dissect his every move and irrevocably affix the tag ‘irresponsible’ against his name. Pant and his fans, of whom there are millions, will happily take ‘irresponsible’ if it comes with 3,662 runs in 51 Tests, at a high average of 43.59 (which will put several specialist batters to shame), a stunning strike-rate of 74.21 and with eight wonderful centuries from 89 innings.

These same critics have wondered how much more productive Pant would have been had he not given into the striking streak of the maverick that oozes from every pore in his body. But then, he wouldn’t be Pant, would he? From Ravi Shastri to Rahul Dravid and perhaps grudgingly, Gautam Gambhir, and from Virat Kohli to Rohit Sharma and Shubman Gill, coaches and captains have generally desisted from constantly being in Pant’s ear, asking him to restrain himself and play in a manner than doesn’t come naturally to him. Pant has tried his utmost to not disappoint them, but from time to time, it is inevitable that he will fall back on his natural instincts, which is to hunt the bowlers down and establish his authority before they can even dream of starting to call the shots.

Just the other day in Galle, there was a spirited if somewhat banal discussion in the press box during one of the numerous rain-stoppages about whether Pant would retain his place in the playing XI for the second Test against Sri Lanka, starting at the SSC ground on Sunday. Actually, it was more than just a discussion; all those involved in that conversation were adamant that with Dhruv Jurel finding his range, perhaps there was a case for Pant to be dropped, for Jurel to take over the big gloves and for Sarfaraz Khan, a late replacement for the injured Sai Sudharsan, to return to Test action after 21 months in the wilderness.

The sheer vehemence and tone took one by surprise. It’s Rishabh Pant they were talking about, dismissing him as someone who was expendable, dispensable and eminently droppable. Admittedly, this was before his blazing 66 in the second innings, but even so, leave out Pant? Really? How does that even work? Perhaps, returns of 81 and 39 in his two previous Test innings didn’t count for much in these pundits’ books? Maybe, they were so incensed by his charge down the track to swat Keshara Nuwantha’s left-arm spin to mid-off that they felt he needed to be taught a lesson, to be put in his place?

Perceived ‘irresponsible’ batting

Indian cricket is no stranger to players being sanctioned for perceived ‘irresponsible’ batting. Kapil Dev is one of the more visible victims of this tack,



dropped from the Kolkata Test against England in 1984 after holing out to long-on in the loss in the second Test at New Delhi’s Feroze Shah Kotla ground. If Kapil’s omission was a witch-hunt of sorts, as whispers have indicated, it was ‘beautifully’ couched with Sandeep Patil emerging as collateral damage. Kapil returned to the playing XI for the fourth Test in Chennai and graced the five-day game for another decade, while Patil didn’t don the white flannels ever again.

But while egos might still be as prevalent now as they were more than four decades ago, the chances of leaving out a star player or two on a whim are miniscule to non-existent in the social media-driven era where it is hardly fanciful to whip up public sentiment and support. In any case, no one in his senses will (or at least, should) seriously contemplate ‘benching’ Pant on disciplinary grounds because why would you want to go into a Test match with one hand tied behind your back?

Perhaps, Pant was seized of the isolated overreactions to his first-innings misadventure when he tried to hit the cover off the cherry immediately after Sri Lanka summoned the second new ball and perished to the fourth ball of the first over, clattering Nuwantha into the deep field. Perhaps, he felt the need to convince himself, more than anyone else (he is, after all, the monologue king while batting, often advising or berating himself), that he could play the situation, that his game awareness was second to none, and that his discipline isn’t as fragile or tenuous was the world might believe.

No matter why, Pant batted a lot more within himself in India’s second innings, which they began with a lead of 178. There was a platform for him to build on, perhaps with typically explosive swag; India were 81 for three, 259 runs to the good, when Pant walked out to replace Gill. The foundation established, he could

have chosen to cut loose from the get-go, but Pant employed an entirely different tactic.

Wonderful basics

Like all great destroyers of bowling, Pant has wonderful basics that don’t get enough credit. His defence is rock solid, though when he does offer a dead bat, it often feels like he is toying with the bowler. On Tuesday, he used barndoor defence to great effect, if only because... Not until his 14th ball did the Pant of usual, the impish and cheeky version, surface, through a reverse sweep against Nuwantha that sped away to square third-man for four. A little while later, after another stonewalling rigmarole, he ran at Lahiru Kumara faster than the Sri Lankan quick ran at the bowling crease, took the ball on top of its bounce and flat-batted with such ferocious power that the ball sailed well out of the stadium and scattered the pedestrians milling around the historic Dutch fort.

Pant took a liking to Kumara, pulling him over long-leg for six to bring up an eye-catching half-century and then smacking him for two fours in the pacer’s next over. Kumara might have had the last laugh as an attempted pull lobbed off the miscue into Dickwella’s gloves; by then, Pant had smashed 66 in just 69 deliveries, with eight fours executed with utmost precision and the two sixes off Kumara.

The second of those ‘maximums’ took him to not just his 20th half-century but also to 100 sixes in Test cricket. That’s no mean accomplishment, lest we should begin to think so. Until Pant, only three other batters had got to that rare milestone - the retired trio of Ben Stokes, Brendon McCullum and Adam Gilchrist. Hitting sixes in Test cricket is evidently not as easy as it might seem, or as easy as it is in the T20 format particularly. To therefore be in a select quartet is a grand achievement but when it comes to Pant,

there are no half-measures, right?

The former India vice-captain got to that landmark in his 89th innings, a good 41 knocks faster than Gilchrist. On its own, that doesn’t mean too much because it’s more than possible that several of these knocks didn’t extend beyond ten deliveries. A more acceptable barometer when it comes to measuring rate of six-hitting is balls faced, which can then translate to balls per six. Gilchrist’s 100 sixes came in 6578 deliveries, which is roughly a six every 65.78 balls; Pant needed only 4918 balls to get to that same destination, meaning he strikes a six more than 16 deliveries quicker than his Australian counterpart. Talk about impact. Talk about destructive power. Talk about unchecked mayhem. Talk about game-changing influence.

As India brace for eight Tests in the next seven months, including two in New Zealand, they will need Pant firing on all cylinders. He will continue to annoy and anger with rushes of blood that are such an integral part of his DNA that there is no way he can excise them totally from his system. But he will also turn on the heat, the power, the potential for damage that perhaps no one else in world cricket currently possesses. Pant is the consummate professional but whether by accident or design, he is also the ultimate entertainer, lying flat on his back after playing a sweep for six or setting a field for himself when he is batting, like he convinced Bangladesh captain Najmul Hossain Shanto into doing in the Chennai Test of September 2024.

Pant can’t be excepted from accountability - no one is bigger than the team, ever - but he can’t also be expected to be something he isn’t. We must accept him for what he is, warts and all, because Pant is the master of his own world and we all cricket-crazy investors are privileged enough to be allowed entry into that very private space.

THE GIST

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HEALTH

Why are South Asians missing from global health databases

Advances in AI are allowing scientists to mine vast amounts of genomic data to detect disease earlier, predict risk and tailor treatments to individuals; but at the heart of this lies an old, constant problem – the data used to build these tools lack diversity; South Asian scientists now want to build their own tools

Rupsy Khurana

Globally, more than one in 10 adults now live with diabetes. If you have South Asian roots, that risk is even higher, and it hits earlier than it does in many other populations. In India alone, the number of people with diabetes is projected to reach 125 million by 2045.

Yet, when scientists try to understand why diseases such as diabetes and cardiovascular disease affect South Asians differently, they often have to rely on genetic data drawn from European populations.

Advances in artificial intelligence and machine learning are allowing scientists to mine vast amounts of genomic and health data to detect disease earlier, predict risk, monitor patients and tailor treatments to individuals. But at the heart of this changing landscape lies an old, constant problem – the data used to build these tools lack diversity.

The missing factor

Integrated biobanks such as the U.K. Biobank, which combine participants' genomic information with electronic health records, environmental exposures and lifestyle data, have transformed biomedical research. These repositories have accelerated drug development, informed clinical guidelines and helped shape public health policy across the world.

But South Asians remain largely absent from these datasets. The NHGRI-EBI GWAS Catalogue, an online database of human genome-wide association studies, shows that between 2005 and 2025, more than 86% of participants in these studies were of European ancestry, while South Asians accounted for less than 1%.

"More than 20% of the world is being neglected in multi-modal data integration," said Bhramar Mukherjee, senior associate dean of public health data science and data equity, Yale School of Public Health, U.S.. "It denies [them] the human right and opportunity to attain the maximal possible health".

A recent study

The pattern repeats in newer tools, too. A recent study published in *Cell Genomics* reviewed more than 13,500 samples across three major single-cell resources – the Human Cell Atlas, the Human Tumour Atlas Network and the PsychAD Consortium and found a "striking, pervasive European over representation and under-representation of Asian and Latino individuals."

"These single-cell atlases are becoming the reference maps for biology and medicine, and they are increasingly used to train the AI models that will shape future research and care," said Kuan-lin Huang, senior author of the study, who is an associate professor of genetics and genomic sciences, and AI in human health, at the Icahn School of Medicine, United States.

These data points are more than just statistics. South Asians face higher rates of type 2 diabetes, cardiovascular disease and asthma than people of European ancestry, which means the tools built on European-heavy data are less accurate for the population that needs them most.

Take polygenic risk scores, which combine the effects of many genetic variants associated with a disease to estimate a person's overall genetic risk.

A 2023 study found that polygenic risk scores for multiple sclerosis were less accurate when applied to South Asian populations.

"Most predictions about how variants affect gene expression or cell function are inferred from European datasets, and we don't know which of those predictions hold in South Asians. This limits our ability to understand disease mechanisms and identify drug targets relevant to South Asian populations," said Shweta Ramdas, a geneticist based in Bengaluru.

Genetic traits

Even the well-established measures of disease risk can vary between populations. Genetic traits such as G6PD deficiency, which can cause a type of anaemia, vary considerably across South Asia, with some ethnic groups in Pakistan and Afghanistan carrying the trait at much higher rates than others.

Another study from Sri Lanka found that cardiometabolic risk did not fit into a single metabolic syndrome profile. Even within the same population, men and women showed distinct patterns of obesity, blood sugar, cholesterol and blood pressure.

"Diagnostic thresholds, risk scores and prediction models developed predominantly from European populations should be validated and, where necessary, recalibrated using South Asian data. Locally generated evidence is essential for equitable and accurate health care," said Athula Sumathipala, director, Institute for Research and Development in Health and Social Care, Sri Lanka.

South Asia is not one population

South Asia constitutes one of the most diverse human populations in the world, shaped by thousands of years of migration, cultural diversity, endogamy and consanguineous marriages.

Much of the existing research does not reflect this diversity. South Asians, Southeast Asians, West Asians and other Asian populations are often lumped together, obscuring important differences between them.

India alone illustrates how much diversity can disappear when populations are treated as a single group. The GenomeIndia Project, launched in 2020 to capture the country's genetic diversity and build a reference database for Indian populations, has already identified more than 40 million genetic



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Director, Institute for Research and Development in Health and Social Care, Sri Lanka

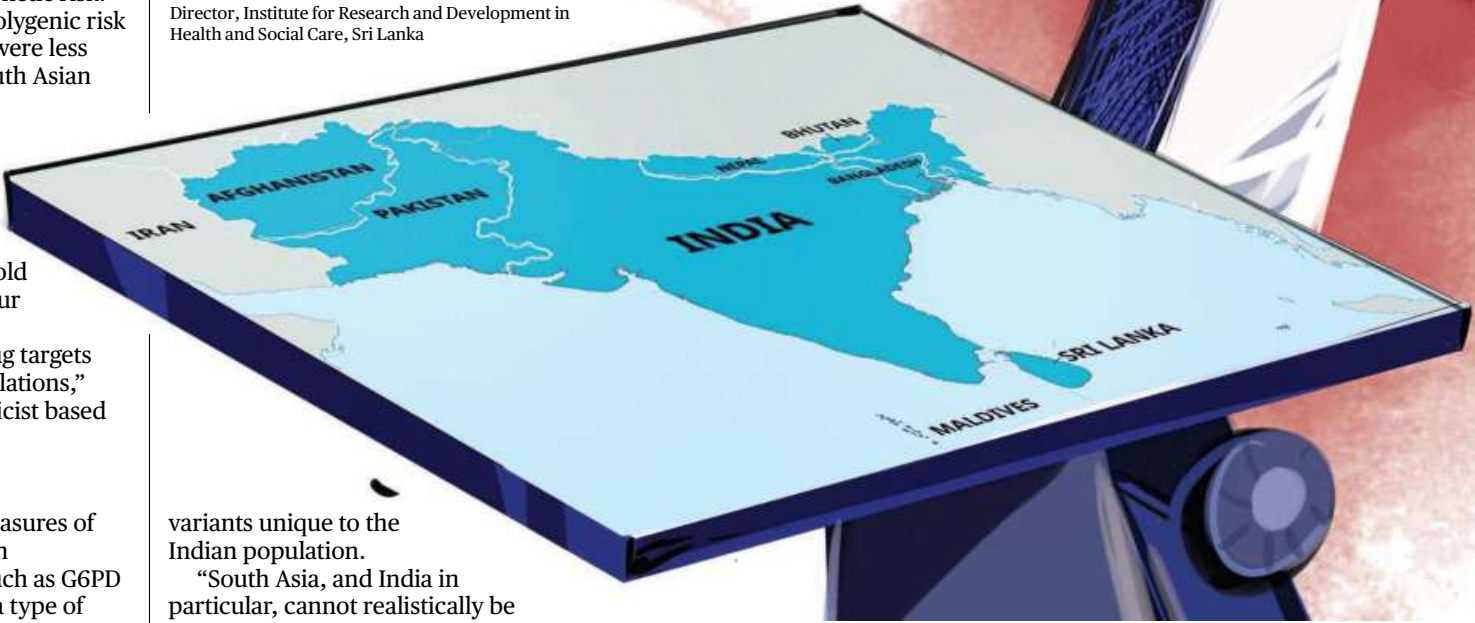


ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

variants unique to the Indian population.

"South Asia, and India in particular, cannot realistically be treated as one genetic block. We need to include distinct endogamous and tribal groups, not just a few urban cohorts," said Dr. Ramdas. "A lot of these harmful variants aren't seen anywhere else".

Why is the data missing?

Research funding, institutions, registries, biobanks and large population cohorts have historically been built and sustained where the money already was, leaving low- and middle-income countries with inadequate laboratory infrastructure, biobanking facilities and trained personnel to run comparable studies at scale.

"The global health landscape remains deeply unequal. While over 90% of the world's potential years of life lost occurred in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs), only about 10% of global health research funding addressed their health needs," said Dr. Sumathipala. "This imbalance goes beyond money, shaping whose problems are studied, whose questions are prioritised and whose evidence informs health policy and practice".

For most South Asian countries, genomic research can be difficult to prioritise given more immediate and pressing public health needs such as infectious diseases, maternal and child health and non-communicable diseases.

But the region has made strides in the health landscape. Sustained investments in genomics have enabled several large prospective cohorts and population datasets, including GenomeIndia, Phenome India, Longevity India, the Sri Lankan Twin Registry Biobank and the Pakistan Genome Resource. But these independent cohorts and biobanks are

mostly focused on individual diseases or specific populations, and often use different systems for collecting and storing data, which makes it difficult to bring them together for large genetic studies. India, for example, has several sizeable cohorts, but no harmonised system yet exists that lets researchers within and across borders work across them easily.

Towards building a beginning

A recent perspective in the *Lancet Regional Health - Southeast Asia*, authored by scientists across India, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka, argues that the region risks being excluded from the genomic revolution unless it builds an infrastructure itself. The authors propose building greater regional collaboration between existing biobanks and cohorts, while ensuring that South Asian researchers and institutions retain a meaningful role in how their data are used.

They propose to build a system in which existing datasets can speak to each other, populations that have historically been overlooked can be included, and the researchers generating the data can share in the scientific benefits.

This is vital because if the underlying data continues to stay skewed, the AI models and clinical tools built on top of it will reproduce and repeat those biases – only at a much larger scale.

"It may be late but still not too late," said Dr. Sumathipala.

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THE GIST

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Both sugar and meat powered expansion of brain in humans, finds study

Ramya Kannan

Was it meat or glucose that fuelled the growth of the human brain? If evolutionary science told us, hitherto, that human brain expansion relied on meat to grow, a new study has an interesting addition to this theory. Published in a recent issue of *Science*, the study posits a dual fuel strategy – sugar and meat – as having powered brain expansion in humans.

Multi-centre study

The multi-centre study by Jennie Brand-Miller et al, does not discount the role of meat in brain expansion, but argues that natural sugars and starch found in fruits and honey delivered the required glucose to power a rapidly-expanding human brain. "What foods enabled the evolution of the large human brain? Currently, that diet is usually framed around increasing intake of animal foods: meat, protein, fat, and

omega-3 fatty acids," the authors explain, but go on to model the glucose needs of humans and their ancestors from four million years ago, until recently.

Over a period of four million years, the size of the human brain is said to have increased from around 300 grams in early hominins (bipeds) to about 1,500 grams in modern humans. As brains grew, so did demand for glucose, which is required by other tissues including red blood cells, kidneys and reproductive organs.

"The human brain is unusually large for our body size and requires substantial amounts of energy," Jennie Brand-Miller, professor of human nutrition at the University of Sydney Charles Perkins Centre and School of Life and Environmental Sciences, said.

The study does not dismiss the importance of hunting or animal protein; rather, it establishes that human brain expansion relied on a balanced, dual-fuel strategy. Meat



Diet history: It was natural sugars that delivered the essential glucose required to power a metabolically expensive brain, says study. GETTY IMAGES

provided critical amino acids and micronutrients, while natural sugars and starches delivered the essential glucose required to power a

metabolically expensive brain.

These findings discover a new glucose pathway to brain development – natural sugars may

have supplied the energy needed to support brain metabolism before the advent of cooking which made starch-rich foods easier to digest. The paper is co-authored by archaeologist Karen Hardy, professor of prehistoric archaeology at the School of Humanities, University of Glasgow.

A quarter of dietary energy

Prof. Brand-Miller explained that raw starch will not release glucose, meaning that early humans likely relied on naturally-sweet foods long before cooked grains became a regular part of the diet. The modelling employed by the researchers suggests that sugars provided over 25% of dietary energy, fulfilling the obligatory glucose demand. Pounding and cooking (grains) releases glucose specifically, not merely energy. The evolution of a bigger brain is therefore a story of carbohydrate foods as much as animal foods. "While animal foods were important, the brain's need for

glucose has largely received little attention from anthropologists," she added. Explaining the element that the modelling brings to current evolutionary theory, Prof. Hardy, said: "The human evolutionary diet has a strong focus on meat eating and the need for protein. But we also require energy and this is best provided by glucose obtained from plants."

The earliest hominins such as 'Lucy', whose brain was the same size as a chimpanzee, as well as Homo habilis and Homo erectus, were therefore likely highly reliant on carbohydrate-rich foods, particularly fruit, the modelling establishes. It was only later, as the use of fire and cooking became more widespread, that starch from underground food sources such as wild yams, water lily rhizomes and African potato contributed to glucose intake. This might also explain to some extent why humans crave sweet foods. (ramya.kannan@thehindu.co.in)